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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM DIRECTS TO ADDRESS BPKIHS PROBLEMS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan 16:

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet and Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal to address the demands of the teachers, employees and doctors of BP Koirala Institute of Health Science (BPKIHS) by calling the executive committee meeting.

Seeking information about the latest situation at the BPKIHS, the Prime Minister instructed them to take the disturbances seen in the health services seriously

According to the PM's press advisor Govinda Acharya, the Prime Minister called the Health Minister and the Chief Secretary at his official residence in Baluwatar on Tuesday and instructed them to solve the problem.

"Seeking information about the latest situation at the BPKIHS, the Prime Minister instructed them to take the disturbances seen in the health services seriously," read a note received from the PM's secretariat on Tuesday evening.

COVID-19 RESURFACES IN CHITWAN AFTER 10 MONTHS

RSS
Chitwan, Jan. 16

Coronavirus infection has been confirmed in Chitwan. The virus was confirmed in a 29-year-old youth and a 66-year-old man in the lab tests conducted on Sunday and Tuesday, said information officer of Bharatpur Hospital, Gopal Paudel.

The man has come to the hospital for treatment of pneumonia. He has been admitted to the hospital and the treatment has started. Likewise, the 29-year-old is in home-based isolation.

Public Health Officer of the Health Office, Chitwan, Gitanjali Dhakal, said the infection of coronavirus has resurfaced in the district after 10 months. Corona infection was last seen in the district in March last year.

Meanwhile, the Health Office Chitwan has requested one and all to exercise caution following the confirmation of the coronavirus infection. The office has suggested people maintain physical distance, using masks, and wash hands with soap and water regularly to avoid coronavirus infection.



PHOTO: RSS

Road expansion drive is in progress along Narayangadh-Mugling Road section. The expansion drive is being executed by stopping vehicular movement from 12:00 noon to 4:00 PM every day.

Consultations to prepare SDG review report begin

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

Nepal is gearing up for the third 'Voluntary National Review (VNR)' report on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) with a plan to complete it by the end of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 (mid-July 2024) and submit it to the meeting of the High-Level Political Forum (HLPF) of the United Nations.

Earlier, Nepal had conducted the review of the Agenda 2030 in 2017 and 2020. The SDGs are in implementation since 2015 with a deadline of 2030 to achieve 17 goals and 248 indicators in social, economic and development sectors.

The National Planning Commission (NPC) has begun consultations with the stakeholders and experts to prepare the new VNR report. It held a review workshop in Kathmandu on Tuesday to solicit suggestions on the progress and status of the SDGs implementation as well as the future course that the country should adopt for the effective execution of the goals.

Speaking at the workshop, Vice-Chairman of the NPC, Dr. Minn Bahadur Shrestha, said that the workshop was organised to review the works and results of Nepal in achieving sustainable development goals, good practices of other countries, coordination and cooperation with various agencies and stakeholders, and to receive suggestions.

According to a statement issued by the NPC, Dr. Shrestha said that Nepal was fully committed to achieving the sustainable development goals and all the three levels of the government, federal, provincial and local, are playing an effective role to achieve the set goals.

"SDGs have been localised. The periodical plan, medium-term expenditure structure and annual policy and programmes and budget have covered issues related to the SDGs with priority. Monitoring and evaluation of plans and programmes related to the achievement of those goals have been done in an effective manner," he said.

The upcoming 16th Periodic Plan, which is being prepared and come into effect from the next FY 2024/25, is also being drafted along with an action plan with the goal of facilitating the country in upgrading from the Least Developed Country (LDC) and achieving SDGs by the year 2030. The Sustainable Development Implementation and Monitoring Committee under the coordination of the Vice-Chairman of the NPC is working to prepare the third VNR on sustainable development.

The NPC's Financial Management Division is working as a secretariat for the VNR.

Likewise, speaking at the workshop, Hanna Singer-Hamdy, UN Resident Coordinator in Nepal, appreciated Nepal's performance in achieving the SDGs, and said that efforts should be made for more progressive results.

"Nepal's progress in achieving the SDGs is commendable and is better compared to some other countries around the globe. However, in order to achieve the goals within the specified time, it is necessary to make more efforts together with all parties and sectors," she said.

According to her, Nepal should be more responsible for the SDGs and upgrading to the 'developing country' status since it is the current chair of the groups of LDCs.

Nepal has prepared and implemented the 'Sustainable Development Goals for Nepal 2016-30 Roadmap' following the announcement of the SDGs in 2015 by the UN. The country has reviewed the achievements of the SDGs in 2022 and determined the current situation and future roadmap for the goals.

The country has also developed SDGs Needs Assessment, Costing and Financing Strategy, and SDGs Localisation Guidelines that spell out baselines, targets and implementation and financing strategies for each SDG.

According to the NPC, Nepal has so far achieved about 43 per cent progress in achieving sustainable development goals in the seven and half years since the SDGs were put into implementation.

The 2020 VNR of Nepal has maintained that the SDGs have been well-integrated into Nepal's national development frameworks. It stated that the assessment of the SDGs implementation over the last four years (2015-2019) exhibits some encouraging results.

The workshop was attended by representatives of all relevant ministries, Nepal Rastra Bank, Policy and Planning Commission of all provinces, National Association of Rural Municipalities of Nepal, Municipality Association of Nepal, private sector bodies, governmental and non-governmental organisations, cooperative sector, and other concerned bodies.

According to the UN, the VNRs aim to facilitate the sharing of experiences, including successes challenges and lesson learned, with a view to accelerating the implementation of the 2030 Agenda. They also seek to strengthen policies and institutions of governments and mobilise multi-stakeholder support and partnerships for the implementation of the SDGs.

Earthquake-resilient construction is a necessity: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that building earthquake-resilient structures is not a desire but a necessity.

Addressing the main ceremony of the 26th Earthquake Safety Day held in Kathmandu on Tuesday, Prime Minister Prachanda urged one and all to learn from the quakes of the past to prevent tragedies in the future. Emphasising the need for quake-resistant structures, he said, "We are obligated to build safe buildings. It is a matter of need, not want."

Earthquake Safety Day has been observed every year on the second day of the Nepali month of Magh since 1998 to commemorate the devastating 1990 BS (1934 AD) Nepal-India earthquake. This year, it was marked on Tuesday with the slogan 'Using local resources and technology to build earthquake-resistant structures.'

"Today is the day to resolve to work together to prevent quake-caused deaths, injuries and physical damages in the future," he said.

On this note, the Prime Minister also informed that his cabinet had decided to study the feasibility of insuring buildings and structures, including private homes.

The series of tremors Nepal experienced this year has also highlighted the need for disaster preparedness. "Therefore, I emphasise staying prepared for reconstruction and using locally available resources like rocks and wood to build strong buildings," he said, promising that there would be no delays in releasing budget and framing policies for post-quake recovery efforts.

Talking about Jajarkot earthquake of November 3 last year, the Prime Minister said that the government had provided victims Rs. 50,000 to rebuild their homes. It has further decided to deposit Rs. 10 billion in the Disaster Management Fund from the Constituency Development Fund, he informed.

Moreover, PM Prachanda expressed the government's commitment to strengthening the capabilities of local levels and equipping them for disaster risk reduction. The National Disaster Risk Reduction And Management Authority (NDRRMA) is also working to manage search and rescue equipment, he shared.

53 structures of Kathmandu at risk: DPM Shrestha

Meanwhile, at a separate programme organised by the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) at Bhugol Park, New Road, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha warned that over four dozen structures in the Kathmandu Valley were at risk of toppling during a seismic tremor.

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Western Nepal at risk of megaquake: Experts

BY LALIT BASEL
Surkhet, Jan. 16

On the occasion of the 26th Earthquake Safety Day on Tuesday, experts have warned that Karnali as well as Lumbini and Sudurpashchim provinces face a high risk of earthquake.

At a programme organised in Surkhet, in Karnali Province, Bal Bahadur Tamang, a seismologist at the National Earthquake Monitoring and Research Centre, said that western Nepal had not experienced a large earthquake for the past 500 years. Although the region saw 4,571 tremors between 2022 and 2024, only three were of medium intensity.

He informed that studies had indicated western Nepal could experience an earthquake of a magnitude of 8.6 on the Richter scale. "If such an earthquake hits Karnali and there is no preparation for it, it could result in massive loss of life and property," he warned. Projections show that 11,530 people will die if such an earthquake occurs at night, 7,908 people will die if it hits during a holiday, and 4,894 will die if it occurs during office time.

Dailekh, Jajarkot, Kalikot and Rukum West are especially at risk, Tamang said, warning that Surkhet was also unsafe because of weak structures.

Engineer Ram Krishna Acharya, acting office chief of the Federal Project Implementation Unit, Surkhet, called on all to build quake-resilient houses and raise public awareness to prevent devastation.

Karnali's Chief Minister Raj Kumar Sharma worried that we had not been able to learn from past earthquakes and worried that we would suffer a lot if we did not correct our ways. He lamented that the provincial government tried to conduct a geographic study of the province but could not succeed due to a lack of budget.

Light rain expected in Valley today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

Kathmandu Valley is expected to experience light rainfall on Wednesday, marking the first rainfall of the winter season.

Meteorologists said that the western system has entered the country, bringing with it light rainfall in the Himalayan regions and snowfall in the high mountainous areas.

According to Chiranjibi Bhetwal, a senior meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division of the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, the country is experiencing partial effects of the western wind. Because of the system, there would be cloudy conditions on Tuesday and Wednesday.

Ujjwal Upadhyay, a climate analyst, said that the country is currently experiencing a slight impact of the western weather system, and this influence is expected to persist until Friday.

On Wednesday, the hilly regions of Koshi, Bagmati, Gandaki, Karnali, and Sudurpashchim Province are expected to experience general cloudiness, with occasional changes in the mountainous areas. Generally, the weather will remain clear in the remaining parts of the country, according to DHM.

There is a possibility of light rainfall in one or two places in the hilly regions of Koshi, Bagmati, Gandaki, Karnali, and Sudurpashchim Provinces. Additionally, there is a slight chance of light snowfall in some high-altitude and Himalayan regions of Koshi, Bagmati, Gandaki and Karnali Provinces.

Meanwhile, on Tuesday, Panchthar and Terhathum witnessed snowfall in high mountainous and Himalayan regions. This occurrence signifies the first case of snowfall in the districts this year.

Kumar Rai, of Sukepokhari, reported that areas including Phidim, Pouwabhnjyang, and Lohakil along the Mechi Highway experienced snowfall on Tuesday afternoon.

Similarly, Kalinchwok in Dolakha

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Thousands suffer as services halt at BPKIHS

BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Jan. 16



Early Tuesday morning, hundreds of patients started arriving at the Dharan-based BP Koirala Institute of Health Sciences (BPKIHS), locally known as Ghopa Camp, for different health-related problems.

While some visited the institute as a new patient, others had come for a follow-up. However, the early travel to the biggest health institution of eastern Nepal was only a loss of time and hope for them.

"The doctor had called me for a follow-up on Magh 2 (January 16). I arrived here as told. I stayed in the line for the OPD ticket with many others from 8 am only to find out that the services were suspended today," said Balabhadra Magar, a patient from Pathari-Shanishchare Municipality in Morang district.

"I am suffering from mental issues. Every once in a while, the doctor calls me for a follow-up to keep my condition in check. He then changes the medicine or doses as needed. Now, I am not sure how long the services will be suspended in Ghopa Camp, a centre of hope for many poor people like us," Magar added.

Magar had boarded a bus to Dharan with his wife in the morning. She said, "The lack of treatment adds stress to the mind of a patient. If I take my husband to another hospital, we need to seek treatment and tests from the first step. If a health institute like the BPKIHS gets closed without prior notice, thousands of patients like us are certain to suffer."

Like the Magar couple, Bikash Mandal, a resident of Siraha district in Madhes Province, had also arrived in Dharan with problems in his stomach.

"I came to Dharan some time ago for treatment because of qualified doctors and affordable cost. I do not have enough money to seek treatment at a different health centre. I also cannot return home without getting fit. The sudden suspension of the services has left me in dismay," said Mandal.

According to the institute's officials, professors and doctors are in protest leading to a suspension of all medical services, except emergency ones. The agitated medical professionals have been demanding timely promotion and appointment of existing and new manpower respectively.

On November 6, 2023, an agreement was reached between Dharan's Mayor Harka Sampang Rai and local political party representatives to resume the promotion process from December 18 and complete them by December 31, 2023.

As the deadline ended a fortnight ago and no steps have been taken, agitating officials have resumed the protest.

Moreover, Mayor Rai padlocked the office of BPKIHS' acting Vice-Chancellor Dr. Prahlad Karki on Monday evening as the agitating doctors' legitimate demands were not met despite assurances.

BPKIHS employees informed that Mayor Rai has warned them to not open the lock.

With professors and doctors on strike, medical students have also started demonstrating by complaining that their academic and practical classes were gravely affected. The students have started a protest from Monday.

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Positive environment created for industries: Minister Rijal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

Minister for Industry Commerce and Supplies, Ramesh Rijal who completed nine months as minister, on Monday said that during his tenure he has put efforts to promote the industrial sector in the country, facilitate international trade and investment, and establish consumer-friendly market.

A statement issued by his secretariat on Tuesday stated that the two major border crossings with China - Tatopani and Rasuwagadhi - were brought to full operation and the meetings of the Industrial and Investment Promotion Board were resumed after about 11 months, and the number of industries receiving export subsidies and the share of exports in the total foreign trade have been increased. It said that these were his major achievements as minister.

"Similarly, the Nepal-China trade and transit agreement, which has been pending for a long time, has also been implemented. After Minister Rijal took over the leadership of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, works of reform in Nepal Oil Corporation have been completed," read the statement.



Minister Rijal

According to the Ministry, the major achievements include initial agreement for extending the 62 KM petroleum pipeline from Amlekhganj in Bara to Lothar in Chitwan and constructing a 50 KM petroleum pipeline from Siliguri in India to Charali in Jhapa, and developing greenfield terminals at both the places.

Likewise, laying the foundation stone of a new fuel storage house in Pokhara and Simra airport which had been stuck for the past five years has been done. Starting air fueling facility, auto billing of petroleum products and starting tanker lock system are among the major tasks.

Budget of Rs. 900 million allocated for the export cash subsidy programme has been fully spent and additional funds have been requested. A proposal has been submitted to the Council of Ministers for six announcements for the development of industrial villages, informed the Ministry.

In the current Fiscal Year 2023/24, Rs. 8.13 billion was allocated for the MoICS, of which 19.71 per cent (Rs.1.6 billion) has been spent till mid-December 2023.

Similarly, the Department of Industry has exhibited good financial performance with the utilisation of 73.73 per cent of its allocated budget. Likewise, goiter control programme (Salt Trading Corporation Limited) has used 50.97 per cent. and sustainability programme for increasing Nepal's tea exports has spent 50.96 per cent of its annual budget in the first five months of the current fiscal year.

However, the MoICS's legal reforms initiatives have been pending at the Ministry of Finance (MoF) and Ministry of Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs (MoLJPA). By mid-December last year, 17 different policies and laws had been sent to the MoF and the MoLJPA for their opinion. Of the 12 issues sent to the MoF for opinion, opinion on only three issues have been received while no opinion has been received on three matters sent to the MoLJPA.

NAC's wide-body plane grounded after suffering technical glitch



RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

A wide-body aircraft of Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) has been grounded after a technical problem was detected in it. With this, the passengers bound to Doha, Qatar have been stranded.

NAC spokesperson Ramesh Poudel said the flight had to be stopped as a problem occurred with the flight control sensor of the wide-body plane. Technical repair of the grounded aircraft is in progress now. He said the passengers bound to Doha on this flight will be send to the destination via an alternative flight this evening.

"The passengers of the Doha flight were stopped due to the technical problem in the aircraft last night. Preparations have been made to send the passengers to the destination by another flight at 7.45 pm today. The passengers have been asked to come to the airport at 4.0pm," he said.

Out of the NAC's four planes operating on international routes, a narrow-body plane has been dispatched to Israel for repairing. Flights are affected due to frequent technical glitches in the NAC planes. NAC has two narrow-body and two wide-body aircraft for operating international flights. The 276 passengers bound to Doha from Kathmandu were kept in a hotel for the night.

Mahakali Corridor, backbone for development: NC leader Lekhak

RSS
Mahendranagar (Kanchanpur), Jan. 16

Chief Whip of the Nepali Congress, Ramesh Lekhak, has described the Mahakali Corridor that connects Kanchanpur to Tinkar of Darchula as a backbone for development in the region. The leader who had been here to inspect the opening of a corridor track from Brhamadev of Kanchanpur to Jogbudha of Dadeldhura shed light on the corridor's potentiality to drive prosperity in the region by facilitating the supplies of herbs, fruits and other local products once it comes into operation.

He further highlighted the corridor's capacity to boost tourism development in the region. The leader travelled up to Jogbudha of Dadeldhura in course of inspecting the corridor track. He also paid homage to the Siddhanath Temple in Kanchanpur and observed a festival organised on the occasion of the Makar Sankranti festival.

Site clearance issues have been sorted out in all four districts - Kanchanpur, Dadeldhura, Baitadi and Darchula- and the opening of the track will be progressed up to Baitadi by the next year, according to the leader. Furthermore, the leader pledged the management of necessary budget to implement the 413-kilometers corridor project, transforming it into an economic transit point by linking it to the Dodhara Chandani Dry Port. The construction of the corridor has been underway since the past 13 years.

Of late, it has been planned to develop the corridor as a roadway linking the tri-national point of Nepal, India and China and the recent development includes the opening of a 15-kilometer track from Brhamadev to Jogbudha.

NEPSE index posts 54.54 points growth, turnover increases to Rs.8 billion

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

The benchmark of the share market index, NEPSE, posted double-digit growth on Tuesday, the second trading day of the week. There was no transaction on Monday as it was a public holiday.

The NEPSE index increased by 54.54 points (2.57 per cent) and closed at 2,175.17 points on Tuesday. The index had increased by 31.62 points on Sunday

The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies also increased by 9.26 points (2.38 per cent) to close at 397.43 points today. With the increment of the NEPSE index, the turnover has also increased significantly.

A total of 23,370,053 shares worth Rs. 8.02 billion from 304 companies were bought and sold in 133,061 transactions

today. This turnover is the highest in almost two years. On February 2, 2022, a turnover of Rs. 8.21 billion was recorded.

The daily turnover has also been increasing over the past few days. On Sunday, shares worth Rs. 5.04 billion had been sold. According to NEPSE, the sub-indices of all groups increased today.

Sub-index of the non-life insurance group posted the highest growth of 213.46 points followed by the life insurance and manufacturing and processing group whose indices increased by 195.01 points and 151.08 points respectively.

Similarly, the sub-index of the microfinance group went up by 116.09 points, development bank by 109.57 points, hydropower by 93.43 points, finance by 87.75 points and hotels and tourism by 58.65 points.

The sub-index of the banking group increased by 24.18 points, others by 43 points, trading by 62.38 per cent, investment by 3.05 points and mutual fund by 0.14 points.

In today's transaction, the share prices of 233 companies increased while the share prices of only 63 companies dropped. Share prices of five companies, including Butwal Power Company Limited, United Modi Hydropower, Himalayan Power Partner, NRN Infrastructure and Development and Nepal Warehousing Company rose by 10 per cent in today's transaction.

> The sub-index of the banking group increased by 24.18 points, others by 43 points, trading by 62.38 per cent, investment by 3.05 points and mutual fund by 0.14 points.

Similarly, the share price of Muktinath Krishi Company and Nerude Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha increased by 9.99 per cent while the share price of Makar Jitumaya Suri Hydropower rose by 9.99 per cent. However, the share price of Jyoti Bikash Bank Bond 2087 decreased by 9.99 per cent, Himalayan 80-20 by 9.7 per cent and Prime Debenture 2088 by 5 per cent.

Hyatt announces plans for Hyatt Centric Hotel in Kathmandu



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

Hyatt Hotel Corporation Monday announced an agreement between a Hyatt affiliate and City Hotel Limited to transform Hyatt Place Kathmandu into the planned Hyatt Centric Soalteemode Kathmandu, fully rebranding into the first Hyatt Centric hotel in the country upon completion of a renovation.

The rebrand will come with a renovated entrance and lobby area, a unique sky bar and lounge, and enhanced amenities, according to a press statement issued by the hotel. Every element of this transformation will be carefully curated to embody the distinct vibrancy of the full-service Hyatt Centric brand.

A launch pad to inspire exploration for savvy travellers, the property is conveniently located near the city centre, within a short driving distance from renowned pilgrimage destinations, including UNESCO World Heritage Sites such as Swayambhunath Stupa, Boudhanath Stupa, and Pashupatinath Temple.

Situated in a picturesque valley rich in historic sites, ancient temples, shrines, golden pagodas, and fascinating villages, the hotel's location will make it a perfect choice for contemporary travellers with an adventurous spirit.

"Strategically located in the heart of Kathmandu, we are confident this property will serve as an idyllic home base offering personalized, of-place service and experiences for guests looking to explore the rich history of the destination. The launch of the first Hyatt Centric hotel in Nepal will further strengthen our portfolio in Southwest Asia and solidify the region as a priority market for Hyatt," said Dhruva Rathore, vice president of development, India and Southwest Asia, Hyatt.

Located in prime destinations across world-class cities like New York, Madrid, Mumbai, Bangalore, Tokyo, Hong Kong and Chicago, the Hyatt Centric brand is thoughtfully designed to turn a stay into an opportunity for discovery, targeting millennial-minded travellers who want to be in the centre of the action.

"We look forward to unveiling this hotel transformation, which will reflect our commitment to meeting our guests where they are with exceptional and memorable experiences," said Akshay Golyan, executive director of City Hotel Limited.

"The planned new, locally inspired design and modern enhancements throughout the hotel will create a welcoming atmosphere to encourage connection and cater to the needs of today's curious traveller." "We are confident that this transformation will further solidify our position as a leading hotel in Kathmandu," said Varun Talwar, general manager of the hotel.

"We are committed to providing an elevated guest experience through the highest level of service and hospitality, and we are excited at the prospect of sharing our new, distinctly Hyatt Centric look and feel with everyone."

Hyatt's current portfolio in India and Southwest Asia consists of 47 properties, with 45 in India and two in Nepal. The diverse collections span eight distinct brands, including Alila, Andaz, Grand Hyatt, Hyatt, Hyatt Centric, Hyatt Place, Hyatt Regency and Park Hyatt.

CEOS FEAR THEIR COMPANIES' SURVIVAL, SURVEY SAYS

AP
London, Jan.16

More executives are feeling better about the global economy, but a growing number don't think their companies will survive the coming decade without a major overhaul because of pressure from climate change and technology like artificial intelligence, according to a new survey of CEOs by one of the world's largest consulting firms, PwC.

The survey of more than 4,700 CEOs worldwide was released Monday as business elites, political leaders and activists descended on the World Economic Forum's annual meeting in Davos, Switzerland, and it showed a mixed picture of the coming years. Of the executives, 38% were optimistic about the strength of the economy, up from 18% last year, when the world was mired in high inflation, weak growth, rising interest rates and more.

The CEOs' expectation of economic decline has dropped to 45% from a record-high 73% last year, and fewer saw their company as highly exposed to the risk of geopolitical conflict, according to the PwC Global CEO Survey. That's despite wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, including disruptions to global trade from attacks by Yemen's Houthi rebels on commercial ships in the Red Sea.

Even with the improved economic outlook, the challenge isn't close to over, with the World Bank saying last week that it expects the global economy would slow for a third consecutive year in 2024. The executives, meanwhile, felt worse about the prospects for their companies' ability to weather big changes. The survey shows 45% of the respondents were worried that their businesses wouldn't be viable in a decade without reinvention, up from 39% last year.

Wall Street slips to edge further from its all-time high

AP
New York, Jan 16:

Wall Street is slipping Tuesday to pull further from its all-time high as it returns from a three-day holiday weekend.

The S&P 500 was 0.6% lower in early trading, though it remains within 0.8% of its all-time high set two years ago. The Dow Jones Industrial Average was down 204 points, or 0.5%, as of 9:45 a.m. Eastern time, and the Nasdaq composite was 0.6% lower.

Morgan Stanley sank 3% after it said a legal matter and a special assessment knocked $535 million off its pretax earnings for the final three months of 2023, while PNC Financial Services Group fell 3% after reporting weaker results analysts expected. Goldman Sachs was swinging between losses and gains after reporting quarterly results that topped Wall Street's forecasts.

Companies across the S&P 500 are likely to report meager growth in profits for the fourth quarter from a year earlier, if any, if Wall Street analysts' forecasts are to be believed. Earnings have been under pressure for more than a year because of rising costs amid high inflation.

But optimism is higher for 2024, where analysts are forecasting a strong 11.8% growth in earnings per share for S&P 500 companies, according to FactSet. That, plus big expectations for several cuts to interest rates by the Federal Reserve this year, have helped the S&P 500 rally to 10 winning weeks in the last 11.

Treasury yields have already sunk sharply in the bond market on expectations for upcoming cuts to rates, which traders believe could begin as early as March. It's a sharp turnaround from the past couple years, when the Federal Reserve was hiking interest rates drastically in hopes of getting high inflation under control.

Easier rates and yields relax the pressure on the economy and financial system, while also boosting prices for investments. And for the past six months, interest rates have been the main force moving the stock market, according to Michael Wilson, strategist at Morgan Stanley.

He sees that dynamic continuing in the near term, with the "bond market still in charge."

For now, traders are penciling in many more cuts to rates through 2024 than the Fed itself has indicated. That raises the potential for big market swings around each speech by a Fed official or economic report.

Yields rose Tuesday to add some more pressure on the stock market. The yield on the 10-year Treasury climbed to 4.01% from 3.95% late Friday. Higher yields can drag on corporate profits, among other negatives for investors, though the 10-year yield is still well below the 5% level it reached in October.

On Wall Street, Boeing fell to one of the market's sharper losses as worries continue about troubles for its 737 Max 9 aircraft following the recent in-flight blowout of an Alaska Airlines jet. Boeing sank 4.7%.

On the winning side was Carrols Restaurant Group, the largest Burger King franchisee in the U.S., which jumped 12.6%. Restaurant Brands International said it will buy all the stock of Carrols that it doesn't already own for $9.55 per share in cash.

Stock markets abroad were also mostly lower, including Japan's, which had been on a winning streak that had carried it to its highest level since its bubble was deflating in 1990.

The Nikkei 225 slipped 0.8% after the value of the Japanese yen strengthened against other currencies. A stronger yen can sap profits from Japanese exporters, and it rose with expectations that the Bank of Japan could be preparing to end its longstanding policy to keep interest rates below zero.

Collaborative efforts must for disaster reduction: CM Pandey

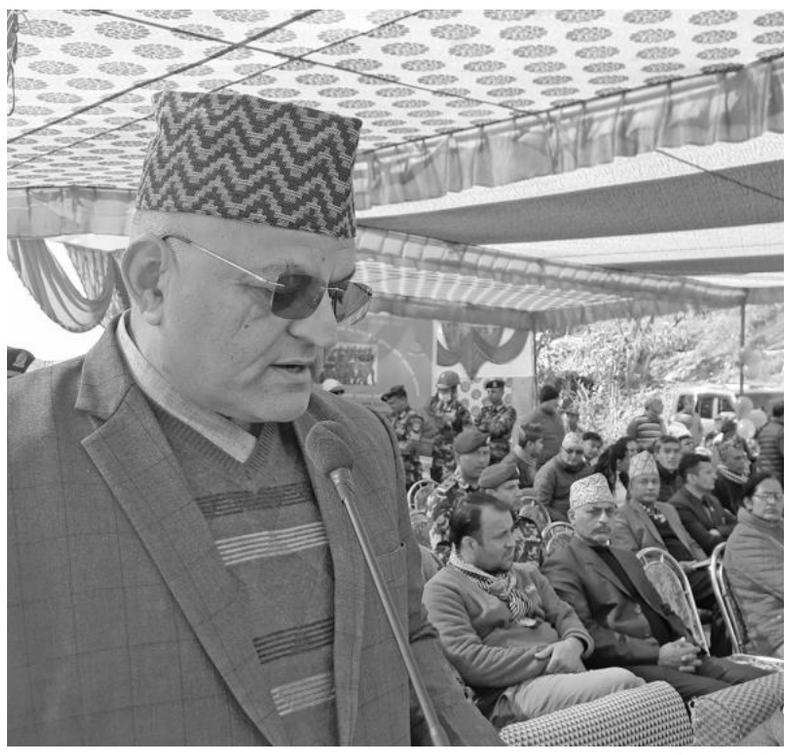


PHOTO: TRN

Gandaki Province's Chief Minister Surendra Raj Pandey addressing 'Community Search and Rescue Training' completion and rehearsal programme in Waling, Syangja, on Earthquake Safety Day, Tuesday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Jan. 16

Surendra Raj Pandey, the Chief Minister of Gandaki Province, has highlighted disaster management as the top priority of the provincial government and appealed for collaborative efforts for disaster reduction.

Speaking at the 'Community Search and Rescue Training' completion and rehearsal programme in Waling, Syangja, on Earthquake Safety Day on Tuesday, Chief Minister Pandey highlighted the need for prioritising rescue, search, and relief activities to save lives during disasters.

Pandey acknowledged the unpredictable nature of disaster-related challenges and asserted that cooperation and collaboration were crucial for effective disaster management.

He disclosed that the federal government has allocated a fund of Rs.100 million at the provincial level and Rs. 1 million in the districts to address the calamities effectively.

CM Pandey also highlighted the proactive measures applied by the provincial government taking into consideration the geographical features of Gandaki Province. "The provincial government has trained 20 divers and kept them ready to respond promptly to emergencies."

Under the annual development programme of the Gandaki Province Government for the fiscal year 2023/24, a programme conducted by the Armed Police Force included practising rescue and first aid operations in various disaster scenarios such as earthquakes, floods, landslides, and river-related mishaps.

Dev Raj Joshi, Deputy Superintendent of the Armed Police Force, said that a rescue drill was conducted in Andhikhola, in Waling Municipality-9 by the No. 30 company of the Armed Police, as a part of the Earthquake Safety Day observance.

Health Insurance Board implements 10% co-payment system to limit random tests

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

In a recent development, the Health Insurance Board has introduced a co-payment system requiring insured individuals to contribute 10 per cent of their treatment costs. Dr. Damodar Basaula, Executive Director of the Health Insurance Board, stated that this new measure, effective from January 15, aims to address the issue of insured patients pressing doctors for unnecessary 'whole body' health examinations.

The motivation behind the 10 per cent co-payment, as explained by Basaula, is to discourage unnecessary medical tests prompted by insured individuals who feel their entitled benefits are underutilised by the hospitals.

नेपाल सरकार
स्वास्थ्य बीमा बोर्ड
टेकु, काठमाडौं, नेपाल, फोन : ९७७-०१-४१००२२३
Health Insurance Board

In response to concerns about certain private hospitals conducting random tests on patients with health insurance coverage, the co-payment system places 10 per cent of the financial responsibility on the insured individual.

Dr. Gunraj Lohani, Chairperson of the Health Insurance Board, expressed optimism about the positive impact of the co-payment system. He believes that the implementation of this system will deter insured individuals from insisting on unwarranted tests by citing pending insurance fees, thereby leading to an overall improvement in health insurance practices.

The 10 per cent co-payment system will be applicable across various services provided by designated hospitals, encompassing external and internal medical procedures, diagnostic tests, therapeutic interventions, surgeries, physiotherapy, rehabilitation, and more. Notably, this provision excludes programmes offered free of charge by the Nepal government, such as maternal protection, childhood disease management, tuberculosis and leprosy treatments, and various public health services.

Dr. Lohani clarified that the co-payment system would not be enforced in primary health centres, government hospitals with up to 25 beds, and specific government-run programmes. Furthermore, the revised cost of the Outpatient Department (OPD) package has been announced, reducing fees for insured individuals from Rs. 200 to Rs. 50, and emergency fees from Rs. 400 to Rs. 100.

WILD BOAR KILLS ONE IN DOTI

BY KESHAB CHANDRA MAHARA
Dipayal, Jan. 16

A 35-year-old woman died and a 72-year-old man was injured in a wild boar attack in Doti.

Jaguli Devi Bhul of K. I. Singh Rural Municipality -1 died on the way to the hospital for treatment. Bhagi Bhul of the same rural municipality was injured when the wild boar attacked him on Tuesday morning.

Jaguli Devi had passed away before reaching the hospital, said Nirajan Shrestha, Director of the District Hospital. Another victim, Bhagi, is in a stable health situation, he informed.

Police Inspector Sitaram Bista of the District Police Office in the district informed that the incident occurred when a wild boar attacked them when they were cutting grass in a nearby field.

Every year, people face life-threatening situations due to attacks by wild animals, such as bears and wild boars in the district.

Week long yoga camp started in Jumla

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Jan 16

The origin of yoga dates back to the Vedic period, but recently people started practicing yoga to find peace and mental balance and reduce stress induced by modern lifestyle.

On the occasion of the 9th National Yoga Day, a week-long yoga camp has been organised in Jumla. Nanda Prasad Neupane, the Acting Chief of Ayurveda Health Centre, Jumla said, "The yoga practice camp was organised by Ayurveda Health Centre of Jumla in coordination with the District Administration Office."

The week-long yoga camp has started in Jumla on World Yoga Day with rallies and slogans.

In the camp that started from Tudikhel government employees, people's representatives and locals are expected to practice yoga every morning.

Dr. Pratibha Sharma of Ayurveda Health Center, Jumla said that regular yoga practice improves strength, balance, and flexibility and helps manage strength.



PHOTO: TRN

Government employees, people's representatives and locals of Jumla are practising Yoga at Tudikhel of Jumla on the occasion of 9th National Yoga Day.

"Yoga promotes better self-care as a regular practice helps in reducing stress, managing anxiety and boosting mood. Thus yoga is essential for mental health as well" said Sharma.

The National Yoga Day is celebrated every year on Magh 1 (January 15) in Nepal to make people aware of the importance and benefits of yoga.

This year's Yoga camp has started with the slogan 'Let's do yoga, stay healthy'. It will be practiced at the Tudikhel ground of the Nepal Army for a week.

Gaurinanda Acharya, Chief of the District Coordination Committee, said that yoga is a Vedic medicine system, and we need to make people acquainted with its numerous benefits.

"Yoga boosts blood circulation, lowers the risk of heart disease, and provides flexibility to the muscles and improves concentration, thus I urge all to practice it as an art and science of healthy living," said Raj Bahadur Mahat, the Chief of Civil Society.

Fire guts shop in Chainpur



PHOTO: SHAILENDRA ROKAYA/TRN

Locals, security personnel and firefighters gather to extinguish a fire at Chainpur, the district headquarters of Bajhang, Monday afternoon.

BY SHAILENDRA ROKAYA
Bajhang, Jan. 16

Junga Bahadur Store, one of the oldest shops in the main market area of Chainpur, the district headquarters of Bajhang, unprecedentedly caught fire Monday afternoon at around 1 pm.

On the vibrant day of Maghe Sankranti, locals started calling every individual with access to the Jayaprithvi Municipality's fire engine, including the mayor, as soon as they saw smoke from the shop.

"It took 20-25 minutes for the fire engine to arrive. Had it arrived earlier, the fire would not have led to such excessive damage," said Keshab Rokaya, former chairman of Ward No. 11 of the municipality.

"My father Saman Singh Byasi started doing business in Chainpur in 1975. The shop is a history in itself. I took over the shop completely after my father's demise. However, now it is destroyed," said Birendra Singh Byasi, owner of the store.

It took around an hour for the firefighters, security personnel from the Police, Nepali Army and the Armed Police Force, and locals to extinguish the fire. Until then, goods worth millions of rupees were turned to ashes.

Byasi suspects the fire was a result of an electric short circuit. "I light an electric lamp in front of the gods. The lamp might have led to an electric short circuit causing the fire."

Meanwhile, locals of Chainpur were angered by the municipality's response to the fire incident. In a bid to make the local level more responsible to its citizens, the locals of Chainpur shut down the market on Tuesday to exert pressure on authorities.

"We called every individual in the municipality office requesting to send the fire engine at the earliest. However, the officials did not respond efficiently. They defended saying it was a day of public holiday. We closed the market on Tuesday to aware the authorities regarding their responsibilities 365 days a year," said Bikram Singh Mahar, a local businessman of Chainpur.

"I also received calls from the locals seeking the fire engine. I directed the firefighters to reach the site as soon as possible. However, since it was a public holiday, there was some delay. Moreover, the fire engine had to use a longer route to reach the incident site due to narrow roads in Chainpur," said Chetraj Bajal, Mayor of Jayaprithvi Municipality.

Police officers informed that they were investigating the cause of the fire and details of the damage.

NEWS BRIEF

Passenger found dead in train

Dhakebar: A passenger was found dead in a bogie on Tuesday. According to police, 50-year-old Ram Ekwal of Piparadhi in Loharpatti Municipality-4 died.

He was travelling to Jayanagar from Piparadhi for his work, but died in the bogie, said Ranjan Awale, spokesperson for the Dhanusha Police Office.

When the railway staff reached his bogie to check his ticket, he was lying dead on the seat.

His body was taken to Provincial Hospital Janakpur for postmortem.

"The reason for his death will be known only after receiving the postmortem report," Awale said.

Man injured in cylinder blast

Birtamod: A man was injured seriously when the gas cylinder he was using to blow balloons went off suddenly in Birtamod, Jhapa on Tuesday.

Indian national Ganesh Sahani was critically injured when the cylinder went off when he was blowing balloons on the premises of Welsh Model School, Garamuni in Biratmod-7 to decorate the school for its Sports Meet programme.

The 55-year-old man has been rushed to B&C Hospital for treatment and his condition is serious, said school principal Jaya Prasain. One of his legs snapped and his body parts below heaps have been badly injured.

A company named Siligudhi was awarded a contract to decorate the school for the sports event and Sahani was its worker.

One of the students also sustained injuries in the blast. After the incident, the school put off its sports programme.

(TRN)

Mahabir Pun reaches hometown to sell book



PHOTO: TRN

Dr. Mahabir Pun, the founder of the National Innovation Centre is in his hometown Beni Bazzar in Myagdi on Monday to sell his autobiography titled 'Understanding, Dreams and Uninterrupted Journey'.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Myagdi, Jan. 16

Founder of the National Innovation Centre Dr. Mahabir Pun arrived in his hometown Beni Bazzar in Myagdi on Monday to sell his autobiography titled 'Understanding, Dreams and Uninterrupted Journey'.

Born in Ramche of Annapurna Rural Municipality-8 in Myagdi district, Pun has been visiting streets and houses in the area calling for people to buy his book. Raghuganga Rural Municipality Chairperson Bhim Bahadur Bhandari bought two books from Pun who was selling his books shouting 'Mahabir's book has arrived, buy the book.'

On Sunday, Pun was in Kusma of Parbat selling the book. His assistant Chitra Tilija informed that 250 books were sold there. He said, "Today we are selling the book in Pun's hometown. We expect an increase in the selling here."

The price of his 308-page book is set at Rs. 750.

Notice for Intent to award the contract

(Date of Publication : 17 January, 2024)

Pursuant to sub clause 27.2 and 27.3 of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all concerned bidders that it is our intention to award the contract to the following bidder for the Tender Notice No. KSCL/P/ICB-159/080/081 for Supply and Delivery of 10,000±2% MT of MOP as per the Invitation for Bids published on 12 November, 2023 in 'The Rising Nepal' & www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as it is found substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bidder.

Tender Notice No.	Name of the successful bidder	Bidder rate in USD/MT	Total Amount
KSCL/P/ICB-159/080/081	M/S Indian Potash Limited, New Delhi, India	CIP Birgunj - CIP Biratnagar - CIP Bhairahawa- 435.60	USD 43,56,000.00

KRISHI SAMAGRI COMPANY LTD.
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THOUGHT FOR TODAY

People may hear your words, but they feel your attitude.
-- John C. Maxwell

EDITORIAL

Earthquake Preparedness

The other day, our country marked the 26th Earthquake Safety Day, a day dedicated to reflecting on earthquake preparedness since it began in 1998. This is significant as it all started after the devastating earthquake in 1934 that affected thousands of lives and homes. As the country observes this day, it is crucial to take a close look at the progress made and address any existing gaps in our earthquake readiness. One of the slogans chosen for this year's ceremony, 'Use also local resources and technology; let us build an earthquake-resistant structure', highlights a key feature that underpins disaster.

Using local knowledge and materials in construction may greatly contribute to the development of structures that are resilient against seismic shocks. Yet rhetoric alone is not enough; a comprehensive plan has become imperative. Nepal is ranked 11th globally in potential earthquake risks, with major tremors occurring once per century. The earthquake of 2015, taking place more than eight decades after the devastation that occurred in 1934, exposed Nepal's weaknesses. The devastation of killing 8,970 and destroying over one million houses highlights the necessity for building up comprehensive measures for earthquake preparedness.

The recent earthquake in west Nepal in November 2023, which killed more than 154 people and destroyed over 76,00 houses, is a reminder of the continuous danger. However, a 7.8-magnitude earthquake will potentially cause about 21,000 casualties and damage nearly all residential buildings in the Kathmandu Valley, according to the government's assessment of risk conducted by the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA). This projection is urgent and must be acted upon without delay. So, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' acknowledging that earthquakes in Jajarkot, Bajhang, and Doti might be signs of possible earthquakes in western Nepal makes this situation more serious. The problem the Prime Minister has indicated concerning the lack of attention to pre-disaster risk assessment not only lacks corresponding structures and preparation but also requires an immediate solution.

While the government has made remarkable progress in preparing for an eventual earthquake, a concerted effort is needed from various federal ministries up to local governments. The National Society for Earthquake Technology (NSET) must take a lead role in coordinating these activities. The government's promise not to establish another reconstruction body and instead strengthen the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) is an encouraging action. But this commitment must translate into real actions, for example, enhancing the NDRRMA's organisational structure and providing it with adequate resources.

It is also integral for the quick adoption of earthquake-resistant designs, the construction of sturdy buildings, and the sufficient allocation of budgetary resources. The government action to study and report on building insurance for all buildings, including private homes as well as public facilities, should be expedited. Thus, it is at the turning point during its earthquake preparedness phase. Earthquake Safety Day is a timely reminder to bridge the gaps, prioritising risk assessments and solid measures. The government should back swift action with visible road results. In essence, the resiliency of a nation depends not only on policies, but it is ingrained even in its very foundations, beyond structural and policy backdrops. Let this day be a mirror and also the start of transformational change in the preparation strategies.

Check Youth Exodus

DIXYA POUDEL

According to statistics, youths in Nepal are leaving the country for foreign terrains at an alarming rate. Nearly 808,415 Nepali youths left the nation for foreign employment during the year 2023. Likewise, over 108,542 Nepali students opted to study abroad in 2023. This craze of going abroad for employment or education is adversely impacting the human resource of Nepal. Further, a vast number of Nepali citizens apply for EDV (Electronic Diversity Visa) each year. EDV is a lottery system that offers Nepali citizens a chance to earn permanent residency in the United States. Held annually, the application process is fully online and Nepali citizens are seen clamouring to apply for EDV to test their luck.

Nepal is known as a prominent tourist's destination. And visitors who travel across Nepal note the friendliness, amicability and genuine hospitability of the Nepalis. Given the pleasant climate, friendly citizens and the rich cultural and traditional heritage, Nepal should be a great place to live. Only, a lack of educational and employment opportunities leaves its citizens (particularly the youths) high and dry. The idyllic villages are now left with the elderly, infirm and children with the able youths having migrated for foreign destinations in search of employment.

Meanwhile, among the educated class in cities and towns, youths continue to vie for abroad studies. There is an ongoing trend for graduates of higher secondary schools to apply for admissions to reputed colleges and universities in foreign nations. But such youth migration leads to a plethora of problems in the native country. If the most able, educated and competent human resources leave the nation for foreign shores, Nepal is left with a dearth of capable manpower, stunting its growth.

The grass may seem greener in foreign pastures; however, there isn't a guarantee that the youths leaving for foreign lands will find their dreams fulfilled. The American Dream is a challenge to the immigrants in the US. Abroad studies and employment aren't destined for everyone. There are those who find success in foreign nations but there are also those who see their dreams crumble. Most are left homesick amid lack of lucrative opportunities. There are many who live and work illegally. Scattered across the world are countless Nepalis who are yet to see their dreams of abroad success materialise.

But then, the diligent ones who can compete with the global human resources find themselves fulfilling their potential. However, wouldn't it be great if such talents would invest their well-earned resources and knowledge in Nepal? The youths who live abroad return to Nepal in holidays and bring with them tales of success amid the envy of those living in Nepal. And from afar, the success stories of Nepalis abroad can be compelling but the real picture may be far from ideal.

As such, the youths who have chosen to stay in Nepal and study and work in the nation shouldn't feel discouraged or disheartened. Hard work always pays off. Further, opting to stay in Nepal and work in the motherland can be full of rewards and joys. In the long run, the motherland will benefit from the investments and hard work of the Nepalis within the nation. And so will the Nepalis who have tried their luck, fortune and competency in their home country, Nepal.

Connecting Universities With Industries



Prof. Bhupa P. Dhamala

Most Nepali people are probably aware that the position of Tribhuvan University Vice-Chancellor has remained vacant for a couple of months (not to misunderstand the fact that a provisional arrangement of an Acting Vice Chancellor has been made for a maximum of three months). Nepali scholars and stakeholders are engaged in making discourse about how a university apex executive has to be selected and what type of person should hold that position. Various means of communication including social media are replete with these or those ideas or arguments that are neither exhaustive nor conclusive. This is but natural.

Currently, two consecutive notices have come out on behalf of the Vice Chancellor Recommendation Committee nominated by the Chancellor. The previous notice mentioned several provisions one of which was much criticised by the public. That was about the experience of a university scholar who had worked as an executive official for at least three years at the university (the same or any other was confusing). Only a few people supported this idea arguing that a person who previously had worked as Rector, Registrar, Dean, Director, Campus Chief, and Department Head would be more efficient in performance of the apex position.

Groundless criticism

While the first attack is ad hominem criticism targeted at the person but not the concept, the second argument is not completely baseless because seeking an experienced person for a high-level position is the usual trend all over the world although the arguers did not furnish the international instances to substantiate their arguments. Many critics, however, argued that the provision was motive-guided and meant that the Chancellor wanted to appoint a prefixed person (not to mention the name of that intended person the critics mentioned in social media). The justification of critics was that the previously appointed university officials were appointed based on political power sharing. Those critics seemed to be unaware that the high-level officials were not the people picked up from the illiterate community, executive officials of a political party, or the elected political positions of the state mechanism.

This is true that many officials were staunch supporters of the parties they liked but to put all university officials in the same basket is unjustifiable. Nothing can be more demeaning than this criticism of independent scholars who had been appointed to high positions at some point in history (by mistake!). Affected by the bitter criticism of such critics (it may be presumptuous to think otherwise), the Chancellor of Tribhuvan University issued an order to rectify the notice that contained the controversial provision and issue another notice. The next notice duly came out removing the controversial provision that temporarily calmed the agitating situation. But that may not last long.

Many are still saying that this notice is simply for a public show with a different intention inside. They are anticipating that the Vice Chancellor will not be appointed based on the selection process administered by the recommending committee. It will be like prophesising that anybody appointed for the position will be an underqualified puppet of the Chancellor, who would serve the interests of the employer rather than the university's academic affairs. Does this prophesy not lead us to conclude that the Chancellor himself is a person who would work in the best interest of his own through the appointment of the University Vice Chancellor? Why not alter the appointment model then?

> One of the reasons why Nepali youths opt for Australian, European, and American universities is that they can be engaged in jobs within industries while continuing their studies.

First and foremost, we should be engaged in the discourse of what type of education is essential for national development, how the state-funded university should work to achieve that goal, and what type of person can perform well in that direction. Many commissions have been formed in the past and they have suggested good corrective measures to improve the educational quality. But they have gone awry. This is the time to really retrospect the previous situation and pave the path forward. And this is possible if we are serious and sincere. There are at least two things that we urgently need to improve what is often called a worsening situation. One is the internationalisation of university education and another is the connection of universities with industries. Keeping aside the first issue for future writing, I now put some words on the second issue in this write-up.

Anybody engaged in the educational field who has visited developed countries worldwide must have spared a moment to see how reputed universities are doing. Most of the universities are funded by the government as they serve the interests of the state. Those universities are usually multipurpose universities that focus on knowledge and scholarship necessary for the overall advancement of civilisation and culture of the entire society. Some of them are established by the community where politicians and social workers are involved so those universities may not meet the quality standards. Still others are privately funded so they are affected in some way by their founders.

Contribution for growth

The founders of privately funded universities are mostly capitalists who run industries or business houses for profit. Such universities are usually technological universities that focus on innovation, invention, and discovery. Such universities focus on business and management. They establish incubation centres to produce the human power necessary for running industries and business houses. Despite their focus on serving the interests of the industrialists and businesspersons, they nevertheless contribute to the gross national product by producing experts for the economic growth of the country.

Nepal as a developing nation has yet to establish more industries to provide job opportunities to the youths who are fleeing to foreign countries mostly in search of jobs for their livelihood. One of the reasons why Nepali youths opt for Australian, European, and American universities is that they can be engaged in jobs within industries while continuing their studies. We need to learn from them and run many more industries that can be connected with universities in various ways. In this context, the Tribhuvan University Vice Chancellor recommendation committee has to select a scholar for the position who can initiate the action of connecting this university with industries at home and abroad.

(The author is the chairman of Molung Foundation. bhupadhamala@gmail.com)

Ode To A Beautiful Family



Namrata Sharma

INSIGHT

Death of five members of a family in a fatal accident in Chitlang on January 11, 2023 has been carried by the media extensively and the social media has been circulating the pictures of the family which will reside in the minds of all who saw those pictures. But who are these people? They were a simple, family-oriented, middle class Nepali citizens who did their duties sincerely and moved on to make a family who were living in solitude and happiness until the fatal accident uprooted their world and left behind a mother, daughter, wife who keeps murmuring to herself in delirious stages "they are all gone what will I do know?

The house here in Maitidevi and Lazimpat are empty what do I do now?" As I hugged Dr. Shristi Tiwary, she said "Namrata di you just met all of them on new year eve now they are gone," I could only hug her but couldn't utter a word. Then I realised another person was hugging her tightly from the other side Dr Astha Tiwary, Shristi's sister but all focus was on Shristi including Astha herself and her husband Dr Chandan Jha who flew from Germany immediately after hearing about the incident. Shristi and Astha were orphaned at a blink of the moment. Shristi's parents Omkar Nidhi Tiwari and Kalpana Tiwari, husband Dr Mahesh Kumar Gautam and son met fatal death at one spot. Shristi was brave enough to try to save her injured daughter by taking the child to a hospital but it was not possible to save her.

Ideal couple

Omkar Nidhi Tiwary was my first cousin, the eldest son of my aunt, my father's elder sister. From the day Kalpana entered our family she has become a favourite of all. My aunt, her children, my parents and all the family members loved her for the human she was. Omkar Nidhi was known to all the family members as Raju. The relationship between Raju da, and Kalpana Bhauju was of an ideal couple very much there for each other and their two daughters who are the most beautiful children in our family. Raju da was always the dutiful eldest son in a family with eight siblings. After my aunt's death, he was the pillar for his siblings. He suffered from back and leg ailment and Kalpana Bhauju nursed him to health.

After the birth of a daughter and a son from Shristi and Mahesh, Kalpana bhauju automatically took the role of a caretaking grandmother. When she couldn't join family gatherings at my mother's place, she used to say cheerfully that her house has been converted to a baby-sitting place. Raju da and Kalpana Bhauju were also perfect example in having pride over their daughters and never complained for not having a son. Both the daughters became medical doctors and married medical doctors too. Shristi is now a very well-established cancer specialist in the Nepal Cancer Hospital while Astha and her husband reside and practice in Germany. Dr. Mahesh had established a hospital. Raju da and Kalpana Bhauju spent quality time with both their daughters. The sons-in-law took the place of their sons.

> After a traumatic experience, the bereaved person may suffer 'survivor guilt' questioning on why they survived and others died and believe that they could or should have done more to prevent the tragedy.

The loss of lives are always unfortunate, but the loss of five members of this beautiful family in one go is a loss that is harder than other natural deaths. I suppose as the cliché goes there is always a silver lining in every dark cloud and at least the sisters have each other and Dr Chandan Jha together with Raju da's brother Saroj Tiwary who immediately took Shristi and Astha to his home. Extended family structure of Nepal is a very powerful tool for coping with disasters. Shristi's parents-in-law are also there for her support. The medical fraternity is also a very supportive team who will hopefully help Shristi to get back to normal. While Shristi's sorrows are unfathomable so are the sorrows of Astha and her husband and the parents and siblings of Mahesh Babu. The entire family of Raju da is now in a void which will probably never be filled.

Life and death is a phenomenon that can never be separated. However, coping with an incident like this is something that can never be prepared for. I am still in a shock that my cousin, his wife, son-in-law and two grandchildren whom I met on 30th December 2023 are gone at one spot. I cannot imagine how his two surviving daughters and one son-in-law will cope. Being a cancer specialist witnessing death is not a new thing for Shristi but coping with the fact that her entire world is gone is something she needs tremendous strength for.

Survivor guilt

According to the Grieflink site, the grief process can be disrupted if people who have been subjected to trauma become emotionally numb and avoid talking about the issue. They may experience feelings of unreality and fear. This could lead to inability to deal with their inner feelings and to work through the disruptions and loss. After a traumatic experience, the bereaved person may suffer 'survivor guilt' questioning on why they survived and others died and believe that they could or should have done more to prevent the tragedy. According to the Grieflink the memories, particularly if the bereaved person's loved one died in extremely distressing circumstances, may dominate their thoughts, rather than the memories of the dead person themselves. This can become a diversion from grieving for the person who was killed. In that way the grief process may be disrupted.

Giving Ode to this beautiful family I just want to thank lord that Shristi and Astha have each other and Chandan and the departed Raju da is with four other family who went with him. Prayers that the grieving process of the survivors become easier as the days pass by.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate. namrata1964@yahoo.com Twitter handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 17, 1974

Fruit Tree Planted

Tansen, Jan. 15: The Palpa Agriculture has planted fruit trees and vegetables in 104 ropanies of land, says RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Prioritise Quake Resistant Structures

I am writing this letter with regard to the news '*Let's build quake resistant structures by using local resources and technology*' published by your paper on Tuesday. While it goes without saying that all our structures, private or public, should be made quake resistant, we must look at why that is not happening.

The first thing is that building resilient buildings is perceived to be expensive. People think that earthquake-proofing will cost them a lot of money, so they opt not to do it. That is why the case you made for using local resources is very pertinent as it will bring down costs.

Secondly, they do not have good sources of information. Even if someone wants to construct a good building, they do not know who to consult. Contractors are often untrained and do not see the need to prioritise safety over profits and engineers charge fees that not everyone is able to pay.

The third reason is the lack of inspection. Aside from scrutinising the blueprint, local governments do not send anyone to monitor the construction of any building. We saw this first hand in the Summit Apartments case. The Lalitpur Metropolitan City only sprang into action after the accident occurred.



PHOTO SOURCE: JICA

That is why, while lauding your news, I would like to ask you and all other esteemed media organisations of our country to dig deeper in this issue.

Biswas Khadka
Lubhu, Lalitpur

TAILPIECE

A young woman, pursuing a graduate degree in art history, was going to Italy to study the country's greatest works of art.

Since there was no one to look after her grandmother while she was away, she took the old lady with her

At the Sistine Chapel in the Vatican, she pointed to the painting on the ceiling. 'Grandma, it took Michelangelo a full four years to get that ceiling painted.'

'Oh my, 'the grandmother says.

'He and I must have the same landlord.'

Regional tensions escalate, Iran strikes targets in northern Iraq

AP
Irbil, Iraq, Jan. 16



PHOTO: TRN

This image taken from video provided by Rudaw TV shows smoke rising from a building hit by a strike in Irbil, Iraq, Tuesday, Jan. 16, 2024.

Iran fired missiles late Monday at what it claimed were Israeli "spy headquarters" near the U.S. Consulate in the northern Iraqi city of Irbil, and at targets linked to the extremist group Islamic State in northern Syria.

Four civilians were killed and six injured after missiles hit an upscale area near the consulate in Irbil, the seat of Iraq's semi-autonomous Kurdish region, according to the security council of the Kurdish regional government.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said in a statement that it had hit a headquarters of Mossad, the Israeli intelligence agency, in the Kurdish region of Iraq. Another statement said it had fired a number of ballistic missiles at "terrorist operations," including Islamic State targets, in Syria and destroyed them.

Israel did not immediately acknowledge the attack in Irbil and its embassy in Washington did not return a request for comment on the Iranian allegation regarding the Mossad.

The strikes come at a time of heightened tensions in the region and fears of a wider spillover of the ongoing war in Gaza. Since the outbreak of the Israel-Hamas war on Oct. 7, Iranian-backed militias in Iraq have launched near-daily drone attacks on bases housing U.S. forces in Iraq and Syria, which the groups have said was in retaliation for Washington's support of Israel, and in an attempt to force U.S. troops to leave the region.

The United States strongly condemns "Iran's reckless missile strikes" in Irbil, said State Department spokesman Matthew Miller. He said the attacks "undermine Iraq's stability."

A U.S. defense official who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss details that had not been made public said the U.S. tracked the missiles, which hit in northern Iraq and northern Syria, and no U.S. facilities were struck or damaged in the attacks. The official said initial indications were that the strikes were "reckless and imprecise."

However, the full extent of the damage from the strikes could not be independently assessed.

An Iraqi security official said Irbil was targeted with "several" ballistic missiles but did not give further details. An official with an Iranian-backed Iraqi militia said 10 missiles fell in the area near the U.S. Consulate. He said the missiles were launched by Iran's Revolutionary Guards. Both officials spoke on condition of anonymity.

Peshraw Dizayi, a prominent local businessman with a portfolio that included real estate and security services companies, was killed in one of the Irbil strikes along with members of his family, according to a post on X, formerly known as Twitter, by Mashan al-Jabouri, a former Iraqi member of parliament. Al-Jabouri said that one of the missiles had fallen on Dizayi's "palace, next to my house, which is under construction on the road to the Salah al-Din resort." Other regional political figures also confirmed Dizayi's death.

In 2022, Iran claimed responsibility for a missile barrage that struck in the same area near the sprawling U.S. Consulate complex in Irbil, saying it was retaliation for an Israeli strike in Syria that killed two members of its Revolutionary Guard.

Iraq recalls ambassador from Iran

AP
Irbil, Iraq, Jan. 16

Iraq recalled its ambassador from Tehran for consultations and summoned Iran's chargé d'affaires in Baghdad on Tuesday in protest over Iranian strikes on northern Iraq that killed several civilians overnight, the Iraqi Foreign Ministry said.

The Iranian attack was "a blatant violation of the sovereignty of the Republic of Iraq, strongly contradicts the principles of good neighborliness and international law, and threatens the security of the region," it said in a statement.

Iran fired missiles late Monday at what it said were Israeli "spy headquarters" in an upscale neighbourhood near the sprawling U.S. Consulate compound in Irbil, the seat of Iraq's northern semi-autonomous Kurdish region, and at targets linked to the extremist Islamic State group in northern Syria.

Iran's Revolutionary Guard said in a statement Tuesday that it launched four Kheibar missiles at IS positions in Idlib in Syria and 11 precision ballistic missiles at the Kurdish region in northern Iraq, where it said it hit a centre of Mossad, the Israeli intelligence agency. Iraqi officials denied that the building was related to Mossad.

The strikes came at a time of heightened tensions in the region and fears of a wider spillover of the ongoing war in Gaza.

They also came after the Islamic State group claimed responsibility earlier this month for two suicide bombings targeting a commemoration for an Iranian general slain in a 2020 U.S. drone strike. The attack in Kerman killed at least 84 people and wounded 284 others at the ceremony honoring Revolutionary Guard Gen. Qassem Soleimani.

Last month, Iran accused Israel of killing a high-ranking Iranian general, Seyed Razi Mousavi, in an airstrike on a Damascus neighborhood.

It was unclear whether the strikes in Syria had, in fact, hit any targets associated with the Islamic State group.

Mounir al-Mustafa, deputy director of the civil defense in northwest Syria, also known as the White Helmets, said one of the strikes in Idlib targeted a medical clinic that was no longer operating in the village of Talteta in northwest Idlib province. Two civilians suffered minor injuries, he said.

Sami al-Qassim, who lives near the targeted site, said the clinic was empty and there were no militant activities in the area.

The strike in Irbil killed at least four people, among them Peshraw Dizayi, a prominent local businessman with a portfolio that included real estate and security services companies, along with members of his family.

The United States condemned what State Department spokesperson Matthew Miller described as "Iran's reckless missile strikes."

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Nasser Kanaani said in a statement that the strikes in Iraq and Syria were "in line with the resolute defense of the country's sovereignty and security, countering terrorism, and part of the Islamic Republic's punishment against those who threaten the country's security."

He said that Iran in "a precise and targeted operation, identified the headquarters of the criminals and targeted them with accurate and precision-guided projectiles."

UN agency chiefs warn of famine, disease in Gaza

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 16



PHOTO: AP

Palestinian children displaced by Israeli air and ground offensive on the Gaza Strip walk through a temporary tent camp near Kerem Shalom crossing in Rafah, Sunday, Jan. 14, 2024.

Gaza urgently needs more aid or its desperate population will suffer widespread famine and disease, the heads of three major U.N. agencies warned Monday, as authorities in the enclave reported that the death toll in the Israel-Hamas war had surpassed 24,000.

While the U.N. agency chiefs did not directly point a finger at Israel, they said aid delivery is hobbled by the opening of too few border crossings, a slow vetting process for trucks and goods going into Gaza, and continuing fighting throughout the territory — all of which Israel plays a deciding factor in.

Israel's war against Hamas in Gaza, sparked by the militant group's Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel, has prompted unprecedented destruction in the tiny coastal enclave and triggered a humanitarian catastrophe that has displaced most of Gaza's 2.3 million population and pushed more than a quarter into starvation, according to the U.N.

It has also stoked regional tensions, with Iran-backed groups in Lebanon, Syria, Iraq and Yemen carrying out strikes in support of the Palestinians. A missile fired by Yemen's Houthi rebels hit an American-owned cargo ship on Monday, days after U.S.-led strikes against the group over its attacks on international shipping.

In Gaza, civilians have grown desperate. Footage shared online by Al Jazeera showed hundreds of people rushing toward what appeared to be an aid truck in what the news outlet said was Gaza City. The Associated Press couldn't independently verify the video and it wasn't clear when it was filmed.

The World Food Program, UNICEF and the World Health Organization said Monday that new entry routes need to be opened to Gaza, more trucks need to be allowed in each day, and aid workers and those seeking aid need to be allowed to move around safely.

U.N. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres said U.N. agencies and their partners "cannot effectively deliver humanitarian aid while Gaza is under such heavy, widespread and unrelenting bombardment." He said the deaths of 152 U.N. staffers in Gaza since the start of the war is "the largest single loss of life in the history of our organization."

The Health Ministry in Hamas-ruled Gaza said Monday that the bodies of 132 people killed in Israeli strikes were brought to Gaza hospitals over the past day, raising the death toll from the start of the war to 24,100.

The ministry, which doesn't distinguish between fighters and non-combatants in its tally, says two-thirds of those killed in the war were women and children. Israel says its forces have killed roughly 8,000 militants, without providing evidence.

'NKorea will no longer pursue reconciliation with South'

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Jan. 16



PHOTO: AP

In this photo provided by the North Korean government, North Korean leader Kim Jong Un speaks at the Supreme People's Assembly in Pyongyang, North Korea Monday, Jan. 15, 2024.

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un said his country would no longer pursue reconciliation with South Korea and called for rewriting the North's constitution to eliminate the idea of shared statehood between the war-divided countries, state media said Tuesday.

The historic step to discard a decades-long pursuit of a peaceful unification, which was based on a sense of national homogeneity shared by both Koreas, comes amid heightened tensions where the pace of both Kim's weapons development and the South's military exercises with the United States have intensified in a tit-for-tat.

Some experts say Kim could be aiming to diminishing South Korea's voice in regional security matters and communicate more clearly that he would seek to deal directly with the United States over the nuclear standoff, which has deepened amid disagreements over the stringent U.S.-led sanctions over his growing nuclear weapons programme.

Declaring the South as a permanent adversary, not as a potential partner for reconciliation, could also be part of efforts to improve the credibility of Kim's escalatory nuclear doctrine, which authorizes the military to launch pre-emptive nuclear attacks against adversaries if it perceives the leadership in Pyongyang as under threat.

The North Korean steps come as Kim has been actively boosting his partnerships with Moscow and Beijing as he attempts to break out of diplomatic isolation and increase his leverage by joining a united front against Washington.

North Korea also abolished the key government agencies that had been tasked with managing relations with South Korea during a meeting of the country's rubber-stamp parliament on Monday, the North's official Korean Central News Agency said.

The Supreme People's Assembly said the two Koreas are locked in an "acute confrontation" and that it would be a serious mistake for the North to regard the South as a partner in diplomacy.

PRISM

Emu escapes from Alabama home for third time

The City of Calera: An emu named Esmeralda escaped from her Alabama home for the third time and was spotted running loose around town before returning home on her own.

The City of Calera said in a Facebook post that Esmeralda "reportedly had a domestic dispute involving her sister, resulting in Esmeralda making a swift exit from" from her owner's Jemison home.

Sue Sanford, owner of the emu and her sister, Ursula, said Esmeralda is the friendlier bird of the pair, but also the more adventurous one. Esmeralda previously escaped a few years ago and became a local celebrity when she escaped for the second time in December.

Kangaroo escapes Ontario zoo

Ontario: Police in Ontario said residents "were not hallucinating if they spotted a kangaroo hopping around" after a marsupial escaped from a local zoo.

Chatham-Kent Police said in a news release that the kangaroo escaped from the Greenview Park & Zoo and was found wandering loose in Howard Township. "The Chatham-Kent Police Service would like to assure the public that they were not hallucinating if they spotted a kangaroo hopping around Reeder's Line in Howard Township," police wrote.

Amazon delivery driver Alexis Prochniki came across what she initially thought to be a deer while she was driving on her route near Ridgetown.

(AP)

Millions of overseas Brits eligible to vote in polls

AFP
London, Jan. 16

An estimated 3.5 million Britons living overseas will from Tuesday be eligible to vote in UK general elections, in one of the biggest increases in the country's electoral franchise in a century.

The expansion in the electorate follows a change in the law, approved by parliament in 2022, scrapping a previous curb on UK citizens voting if they had lived overseas for over 15 years.

Implemented ahead of an election set for later this year, it is the most significant change to the voter rolls since a 1928 law granted women equal voting rights, and a 1969 move to lower the voting age to 18 from 21.

Britons worldwide will now be able to register to vote online, regardless of how long they have been overseas.

Under UK election law, once registered they will also be permitted to donate to political parties and campaigners.

Around 233,000 overseas voters were registered for the last election in December 2019, a significant Brexit-attributed bump on the numbers seen in previous contests.

The government estimates Tuesday's change could enfranchise around 3.5 million people -- nearly treble the 1.3 million votes that was the winning margin in the 2016 referendum on European Union membership.

It is also greater than the difference in the vote totals for Britain's two main parties -- the Conservatives and Labour -- in five of the last six general elections.

But UK elections ignore the parties' overall vote counts, instead electing lawmakers under the first-past-the-post system in 650 individual constituencies.



PHOTO: AP

A Union flag flutters in the breeze in front of the clock face of the Elizabeth Tower, known after the bell Big Ben, in central London on December 30, 2020.

It remains unclear how many of the newly eligible 3.5 million UK citizens living overseas will successfully register to vote.

They will need to provide details of the address and time they were last registered to vote or living in Britain.

Local authorities, which are responsible for the electoral roll in their areas, must be able to verify an applicant's identity and past connection to the area, according to the Electoral Commission.

Unlike some countries, there is no provision for in-person voting overseas and all ballots have to be cast by post or by using a proxy in the UK.

The Electoral Commission is launching a publicity campaign and working with partner organisations to raise awareness of the rule change.

"We know there are eligible voters in every corner of the world so we're calling on those with friends and family abroad to help spread the news," communications director Craig Westwood said.

Research by Britain's Office for National Statistics suggests the largest numbers of British emigrants are in Australia, New Zealand, the United States, Canada and European Union member countries.

The election law change follows campaigning by various advocates, including the long-running "Votes for Life" campaign led by an overseas arm of the Conservatives.

Heather Harper, chair of the Conservatives Abroad group, said it put Britain on a par with the United States, France, Italy and New Zealand "in recognising the importance of their citizens worldwide".

Prime Minister Rishi Sunak must call an election by January 2025 at the latest, and said earlier this month that his "working assumption" was to have the contest in the second half of this year.

TODAY IN HISTORY

38 BC – Octavian divorces his wife Scribonia and marries Livia Drusilla, ending the fragile peace between the Second Triumvirate and Sextus Pompey.

1362 – Saint Marcellus' flood kills at least 25,000 people on the shores of the North Sea.

1377 – Pope Gregory XI reaches Rome, after deciding to move the Papacy back to Rome from Avignon.

1524 – Giovanni da Verrazzano sets sail westward from Madeira to find a sea route to the Pacific Ocean.[4]

1562 – France grants religious toleration to the Huguenots in the Edict of Saint-Germain.

1595 – During the French Wars of Religion, Henry IV of France declares war on Spain.

1648 – England's Long Parliament passes the "Vote of No Addresses", breaking off negotiations with King Charles I and thereby setting the scene for the second phase of the English Civil War.

THARU COMMUNITY MARKS MAGHI WITH NEW YEAR PLANS

BY DIWAKAR POKHREL
Deukhuri, Jan. 16

The Tharu community which was busy preparing for Maghi since the last week of Poush, is still enjoying the festival.

The leaders of the Tharu community are engaged in reviewing last year's works and making new plans for the New Year, and they nominate their new leaders in Maghi.

Tharu leaders said that they have submitted written reports on the works performed last year and have appraised the past year's works.

Tharu leader Sher Bahadur Chaudhary said Maghi is the New Year of the Tharu community. "Maghi is not only our great festival but also the New Year," he said. Tharu Community enjoys Maghi preparing traditional delicacies and performing their traditional songs and dances.

Min Bahadur Chaudhary of Ghorahi-6, Lakhwar, said that the Tharu community celebrates Maghi by performing cultural dance. From the money raised in Maghi, the dance group uses the money for collective work or organises picnic.

Chhabilal Kopila, an expert on Tharu culture, urged the Tharu community not to associate Maghi with the festivals of other communities. He said, "Maghi is the unique festival of the Tharu community, and this festival is associated with our identity."



PHOTO: RSS

People of Magar community playing archery game on the occasion of Maghe Sakranti festival in Dang district on Tuesday.

ELEPHANTS DESTROY 22 HOUSES IN DAMAK IN A MONTH

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Jan. 16

Elephants have been a big nuisance for various municipalities in Jhapa for recent months.

Altogether 22 houses were destroyed by elephants, causing significant damage in Damak in a month.

Nabaraj Bhattarai, the Vice Chairman of Kachankawal Rural Municipality, reported that on Sunday night, a group of wild elephants demolished two houses in Dalki of Kachankawal-3.

The wild elephants, believed to be from the local Durgabhitta Community Forest, destroyed the tin-roofed houses belonging to Dhula Rajvanshi and Ran Bahadur Limbu. Additionally, the elephants consumed around 1200 kilograms of paddy belonging to Limbu.

Likewise, the elephant herd raided the granary of Dambar Khadka, consuming the stored rice. This has led to substantial losses for local farmers, causing distress and sleepless nights to the affected residents, Bhattarai added.

Earthquake...

Citing a study carried out by the NDRRMA, Minister Shrestha said that 53 buildings and four bridges in the Valley were vulnerable and needed reconstruction. However, he did not provide any names or details of the rickety structures.

He also said that the federal government was ready to help empower local levels to tackle disasters.

Shrestha also expected KMC to play a leading role in assessing the vulnerability of existing structures, feasibility of retrofitting them and making new buildings follow the national construction code.

Thousands...

Meanwhile, Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet had also assured to solve the problems by visiting the BPKIHS recently. Yet, no effective steps have been visible to date.

"BPKIHS has been affected for years due to repeated protests from different concerned bodies. Thousands of citizens have been affected.

The federal government has not been seen concerned. Even the locals of Dharan have protested demanding reforms in Ghopa Camp. The hopes of many continues to be dashed," said Dipak Kumar Budhathoki, an advocate.

Light rain...

district received the first snowfall of the year. The snowfall adorned temples, Ganesh Thumka, Kuri, and Gauri in Kalinchwok on Tuesday.

Other areas like Jiri, Sailung and Kharidhunga also received snow on Tuesday, according to hotel operator Hari Oli. Kalinchowk, the holy hill located at an altitude of 4,842 metres, started receiving snow from Tuesday afternoon.

The lack of snowfall this year has led to a significant decrease in the number of tourists visiting these areas. Kuri, located at the foot of Kalinchowk has 90 big and small hotels to serve the visitors.

European Court rules against Greece in shooting case

AP
Athens, Jan. 16

The European Court of Human Rights ruled on Tuesday against Greece in the shooting of a Syrian man during a coast guard's pursuit of a migrant smuggling boat near a Greek island about a decade ago.

In a ruling, the court, based in Strasbourg, France, ordered Greece to pay 80,000 euros (about $87,000) in damages to the wife and two children of Belal Tello, who died in December 2015, more than a year after sustaining a gunshot wound to the head after Greek coast guards chased the boat he had been traveling in.

The court said Greece had failed to provide an adequate legal framework concerning the potential lethal use of firearms during coast guard operations, and had violated the right to life under the European Convention on Human Rights.

Tello had been traveling in a motorboat carrying a total of 14 people that failed to stop when ordered to by a two-man Greek coast guard patrol boat as it arrived near the small eastern Aegean island of Pserimos on the morning of Sept. 22, 2014.

> The court said Greece had failed to provide an adequate legal framework concerning the potential lethal use of firearms during coast guard operations, and had violated the right to life under the European Convention on Human Rights.

The court said the motorboat's captain "began dangerous maneuvers," colliding with the coast guard patrol boat on two or three occasions and causing limited damage.

According to a report drawn up on the day of the incident and cited by the court, the coast guard fired seven warning shots and 13 shots at the outboard motor, attempting to stop it. Two Syrians on board were wounded; Tello in the head and another passenger in the shoulder. A Greek court tried and convicted two Turkish nationals found to have been in command of the motorboat used for migrant smuggling.

Tello remained in intensive care in a hospital on the nearby island of Rhodes until March 2015. He was then transported in August that year to Sweden, where his wife and children were living, for further treatment, but died in December.

The court found that the level of force used in an attempt to stop the motorboat and arrest its captain was "clearly disproportionate," adding that the coast guard officers "had not taken the necessary measures … to verify that no other passengers were on board" when they opened fire.

The European court also cited shortcomings in Greek authorities' investigation of the incident,

Refugee Support Aegean, a rights organization that provides legal assistance for asylum seekers in Greece and was involved in Tello's relatives' lawsuit, said the case "demonstrates yet again well-documented, systemic deficiencies in the planning and implementation of coast guard operations and in the investigation of human rights violations at sea."

The short but often perilous trip from Turkey's coast to nearby Greek islands has been one of the main routes taken into the European Union by people fleeing poverty and conflict in the Middle East, Africa and Asia.

Donald Trump's defamation trial starts

AP
New York, Jan. 16

With jury selection about to begin, a judge denied Donald Trump's request Tuesday that a defamation trial stemming from a columnist's claims that he sexually abused her in the 1990s be suspended for a day so he could attend the funeral of his mother-in-law later in the week.

The denial came during a combative exchange between lawyers for Trump and Judge Lewis A. Kaplan over evidence in the case, Trump's desire to attend the Thursday funeral and whether the trial should occur at all.

This is the penalty phase of a civil defamation trial stemming from columnist E. Jean Carroll's claims he sexually attacked her in a department store dressing room. A May trial found Trump sexually abused Carroll, awarding her $5 million. Trump did not attend that trial but he showed up Tuesday morning after his political victory at the Iowa caucus hours earlier.

Trump attorney Michael Madaio complained that the judge had made "inconsistent and unfair" rulings against Trump prior to the start of the trial.

Madaio said the rulings "drastically changed our ability to defend this case and largely stripped us of our defenses." He also argued that given Trump's pending appeal of the first verdict, the trial should not proceed at all.

Another Trump attorney, Alina Habba, then requested that the trial be adjourned on Thursday for the funeral of former first lady Melania Trump's mother, Amalija Knavs.

"I am not stopping him from being there," the judge said, referring to the funeral.

Habba responded: "No, you're stopping him from being here."

The judge, though, said the only accommodation he would make is what he announced in an order over the weekend, which is that Trump can testify on Monday, even if the trial is otherwise finished by Thursday.

Trump arrived for the trial in a motorcade shortly before 9 a.m., entering the building through a special entrance not usually used by the public. Opening arguments could take place by afternoon in what is essentially a second penalty phase of a legal fight Carroll has already won.

In May, a different jury awarded Carroll $5 million after concluding that Trump sexually abused her in a department store dressing room in spring 1996, then defamed her in 2022 by claiming she made it up after she revealed it publicly in a 2019 memoir.

The jury said Carroll hadn't proven that Trump raped her.

Trump is appealing and hasn't paid any of that award, though he placed $5.55 million in escrow to cover the verdict and other costs in the event he loses his appeal.

One issue that wasn't decided in that first trial was how much Trump owed for comments he made about Carroll while he was still president.

Determining that dollar amount will be the new jury's only job.

Slovakia's leader voices support for Hungary's Orbán in EU negotiations on funding for Ukraine

AP
Budapest, Jan. 16

The leaders of Hungary and Slovakia on Tuesday said they agree on the need to rework a European Union plan to provide financial assistance to Ukraine. It's a potential boon to Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, who last month derailed EU efforts to approve the funding for the war-ravaged country.

Following bilateral talks in Budapest, Slovakian Prime Minister Robert Fico said he agrees with Orbán's position that the EU should not finance a planned 50 billion euro ($54 billion) aid package to Kyiv from the bloc's common budget, and echoed Orbán's assertions that the war in Ukraine cannot be resolved through military means.

"We have listened very carefully to the proposals that Prime Minister (Orbán) … has already put forward in relation to the review of the budget and aid to Ukraine, and I will repeat that we consider them to be rational and sensible," Fico said.

Fico's comments come as the EU scrambles to salvage the funding package for Ukraine that Orbán blocked in December, a move that angered many of the bloc's leaders who were aiming to provide Kyiv with a consistent cash flow for the next four years.



PHOTO: AP

Slovakia's Prime Minister Robert Fico and Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orban shake hands after a press conference at the Carmelite Monastery in Budapest, Hungary, Tuesday.

Unanimity is required for decisions affecting the EU budget, and Orbán was the only one of the bloc's 27 leaders to vote against the funding.

"If we want to help Ukraine, which I think we need to do … we must do so without damaging the EU budget," Orbán said on Tuesday.

EU leaders are expected to meet again on Feb. 1 to attempt a deal on the financial package, but Orbán's veto power remains a factor.

On Tuesday, Fico said he supports Orbán's recommendation that the funding be separated into four installments that could be reassessed, and potentially blocked, each year.

"I look forward to seeing you soon on Feb. 1 in Brussels, where we will watch with full understanding your legitimate fight for what you started at the last European Council," Fico told Orbán.

A populist whose party won September elections on a pro-Russian and anti-American platform, Fico is seen as a potential ally for Orbán in the latter's longstanding disputes with the EU.

The bloc has withheld billions in funding from Budapest over concerns that Orbán's government has cracked down on judicial independence, media freedom and the rights of the LGBTQ+ community.

Some of Orbán's critics in the EU believe that he has used his veto power over assistance to Ukraine as leverage to gain access to the frozen funds. On Tuesday, Fico cited the withheld funds as a justification for Orbán's opposition to EU funding for Ukraine.

'Quality assurance and uniformity in lawmaking process crucial'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanaraj Gurung has said that the bill designed to manage the legislation was crucial for quality assurance and uniformity in law making process.

During a thematic discussion on the draft of the bill in today's Legislation Management Committee of the National Assembly, Minister Gurung said that the bill was formulated to manage the process to be embraced while issuing delegated legation prior to registering the bill in the parliament.

He argued that the bill is crucial to maintain uniformity in lawmaking processes along with maintaining quality of law, maintain systematic record of the issued Acts and check whether the legislations were made by using the rights delegated by the Acts.

Chairperson of Delegated Management and Government Assurance Committee Maya Prasad Sharma said that the laws drafted against the principle of delegated legislation should be managed by making the bill complete.

On the occasion, lawmaker Khimlal Devkota claimed that framework of irregularity was drawn as the delegated legislation was above the main law in the country and expressed the confidence that the bill would help contribute in the management of such trend.---

Football ground plan in Khula Manch being protested

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16:

Conservationists and heritage lovers are vigorously protesting Kathmandu Metropolitan City's decision to build two football grounds in the Khula Manch area.

KMC has proposed constructing two football grounds at Khula Manch rather than keeping it open to the public.

According to the Campaign, the area has cultural, historical and natural importance, and its encroachment under the pretext of building playgrounds is objectionable.

The Occupy Tundikhel Campaign, the size of Tundikhel has been diminishing sharply since 1967.

The KMC, almost a concrete jungle lacks public parks, open spaces and green hubs, and KMC fails to offer green open spaces where people find peace and tranquility, so the Tundikhel area should not be encroached, they argued.

Bijaya Shrestha, the coordinator of the Occupy Tundikhel Campaign, said that they submitted a memorandum to the chairperson of Ward No.28 on Sunday.

The Khula Manch is located in Kathmandu Ward No. 28 but the ward chair was not given any specific decision about the issue, he said.

The KMC had earlier begun a procedure to prepare a Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the underground parking under the Manch, which is a section of the Tundikhel.

Although a playground is needed in Kathmandu, Tundikhel is not a suitable place for this purpose, he said, "The open platform has its own cultural, historical and natural significance."

The campaigner has demanded that the Tundikhel area should be allowed to remain as an open area as it was.

US MILITARY SEIZES IRANIAN MISSILE PARTS BOUND FOR HOUTHI REBELS

BY JON GAMBRELL/AP
Jarusalem, Jan. 16

U.S. Navy SEALs seized Iranian-made missile parts and other weaponry from a ship bound for Yemen's Houthi rebels in a raid last week that saw two of its commandos go missing, the U.S. military said Tuesday.

Meanwhile, a new ship came under suspected fire from the Houthis in the Red Sea and sustained some damage, though no one was wounded, officials said. The raid marks the latest seizure by the U.S. Navy and its allies of weapon shipments bound for the rebels, who have launched a series of attacks now threatening global trade in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden over Israel's war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip. The seized missile components included types likely used in those attacks.

The attacks, U.S.-led retaliatory strikes and the raid all have raised tensions across the wider Middle East, which also saw Iran conduct ballistic missile strikes in both Iraq and Syria.

The SEAL raid happened last Thursday, with the commandos launching from the USS Lewis B. Puller backed by drones and helicopters, with the U.S. military's Central Command saying it took place in the Arabian Sea.

The SEALs traveled in small special operations combat craft driven by naval special warfare crew to get to the boat. As they were boarding it in rough seas, around 8 p.m. local time, one SEAL got knocked off by high waves and a teammate went in after him. Both remain missing.

The SEALs found cruise and ballistic missile components, including propulsion and guidance devices, as well as warheads, Central Command said. It added that air defense parts also were found.

"Initial analysis indicates these same weapons have been employed by the Houthis to threaten and attack innocent mariners on international merchant ships transiting in the Red Sea," Central Command said in a statement.

NIFF from March 14



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

The official lineup for the 7th Nepal International Film Festival (NIFF) was announced amid a programme held in the capital on Tuesday.

Organising a press conference in Kathmandu on Tuesday, the Nepal Film and Cultural Academy announced that the festival will take place from March 14-18.

According to the organiser, a total of 88 films from 40 countries, selected from over 500 films representing 60 countries, will be featured in the festival this year.

With the slogan 'Celebrating narratives from around the world,' the festival will showcase both national and international films.

Awards will be presented in categories such as feature films, short films, and documentaries, informed the organisers.

KP Pathak, the chairman of the NIFF organising committee, said that the festival will present the 'Gautam Buddha Award,' of 1,500 US dollars to the best feature film in the international competition.

He further added that outstanding feature films, short films, and documentaries would be recognised under various categories.

He expressed the challenge of narrowing down the selection from a multitude of quality films and mentioned that suggestions gathered during the festival would be submitted to the government through the Film Development Board.

During the press conference, Bhuwan KC, Chairman of the Nepal Film Development Board, shared his optimism about the exchange of experiences between the national and international film communities.

He emphasised the board's commitment to providing necessary support for the film festival.

The organisers outlined additional activities planned for the festival, including workshops, interactions, and discussion programmes featuring the participation of experienced and renowned filmmakers.

The first chapter of Meou announced

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

A film titled 'Meou' is set to star actors Anoop Birkram Shahi and Uttam Pradhan. The first chapter of the film was announced on the occasion of Maghe Sankranti.

The film, written, directed, and produced by Jay Raj Roy, is considered an ambitious project for actor Shahi and a comeback film for actor Pradhan.

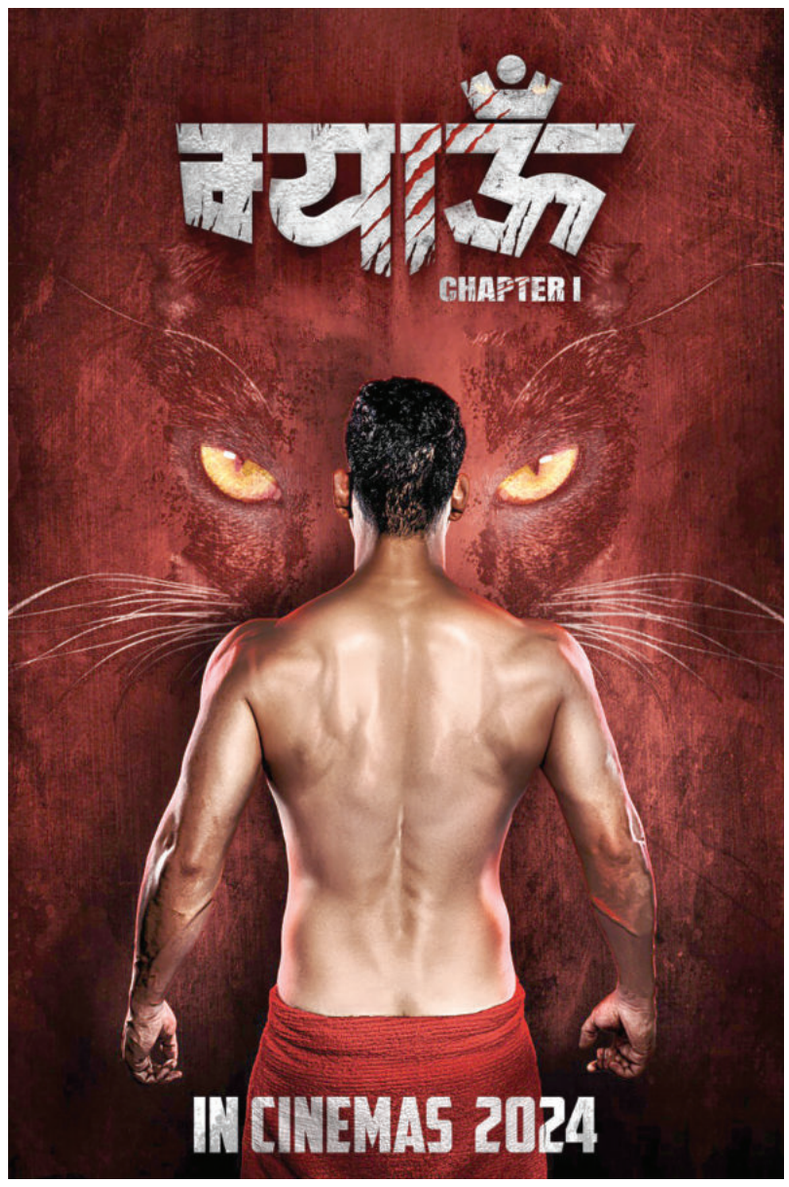
According to director Roy, the film will be produced under the banner of Jay Media Management, with the female lead yet to be finalised. The storyline revolves around a mentally deranged 'psycho killer' with a troubled past.

Roy stated that the film explores the character's existence in society and the situations arising from it, promising a captivating experience filled with twists and turns.

South Indian film music legend Aj Alimirzaq (Naushad Ali) will compose the music, with South Indian film playback singers Sai Vignesh and Padmalatha lending their voices. Sai is known for the song 'Varaha Roopam' from the famous movie 'Kantara' and Padmalata is famous for a 'Kannala Kannala' from the film 'Thani Oruvan.'

The cinematography will be handled by South Indian cinematographer Akash while Laxman Sunar will serve as the associate director and editor. The film is also set to be released in China.

Nisha Khatiwada is the executive producer of the movie, which is co-produced by Jenny Khatiwada Rai, Kendra Regmi and Prince Kumar Chaudhary. Sound design will be handled by Suman Majhi, known for his experience in Bhutanese movies, and VFX by Sudip Bhandari. The global release target for the film is 2024.



24 models selected for IEC Designers Runway



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

The 13th edition of 'IEC Designers Runway' has selected 24 models, with 18 women and six men chosen during auditions held in the capital recently.

The audition, attended by over 350 models, featured a panel of judges including actresses Priyanka Karki and Sabita Karki, Next Models Nepal CEO Ravi Dhamala, commercial photographer Rajbhai Suwal, Mr. Nepal Winner Samarpan Karki, IEC College Managing Director Shailaja Adhikari, and Rajshree Thapa.

The selected models will showcase their talents on the Fashion Ramp at 'IEC Designers Runway,' scheduled to take place on March 29 in Kathmandu.

Additionally, 12 international models from various countries will participate in the show organised by Next Models Nepal.

Ravi Dhamala, CEO of Next Models Nepal, expressed his commitment to making this season the best and most impressive installment of 'IEC Designer Runway' to date.

The renowned fashion show, 'IEC Designers Runway,' has been a consistent annual event, featuring 15 sequels of different dresses crafted by the 2021 badge student designers of IEC College.

Shailaja Adhikari, the managing director of IEC College, highlighted that the primary objective of 'IEC Designers Runway' is to promote Nepali fashion designers and elevate their attractive designs to the international stage.

ELTON JOHN ACHIEVES RARE EGOT STATUS

AP
New York, Jan. 16

Elton John has achieved EGOT status.

The famed British singer-pianist won an Emmy Award on Monday night for best variety special (live) for "Elton John Live: Farewell from Dodger Stadium," a three-hour concert documentary that streamed on Disney+. John said he was "incredibly humbled" for joining the elite group of EGOT winners who have won Emmy, Grammy, Oscar and Tony awards.

"The journey to this moment has been filled with passion, dedication, and the unwavering support of my fans all around the world," John, 76, said in a statement after winning his trophy.

The superstar performer has five Grammys, most recently for "Elton John & Tim Rice's Aida" in 2001; two Oscars for "Can You Feel the Love Tonight" from "The Lion King" in 1994 and "(I'm Gonna) Love Me Again" from "Rocketman"; along with a Tony for his original score on "Aida."

He is one of the top-selling solo artists of all time, and he holds the record for biggest-selling physical single of all time thanks to the 33 million copies sold for "Candle in the Wind" in 1997. John became the 19th person to reach EGOT status after Viola Davis achieved the feat when she won a Grammy last year. Others performers who have EGOTs include Whoopi Goldberg, Jennifer Hudson and John Legend.

David Furnish, John's husband and a producer on the concert special, said John was overjoyed Monday night about winning his first-ever Emmy, and he "screamed out loud." Furnish said a "incredibly honored" John was unable to attend the awards ceremony since he's recovering from recent surgery.

"We Facetimed him. We woke him up in the middle of the night," Furnish said while holding John's award backstage. "He's back in the U.K. He's had his left knee replaced — which isn't surprising when you think of the number of pianos he's jumped off."

'Succession' dominates drama Emmys

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 16

"Succession" secured its legacy with its third best drama series award, "The Bear" feasted as the night's top comedy, and the two shows about squabbling families dominated the acting awards at Monday night's Emmys.

Quinta Brunson of "Abbott Elementary" and Steven Yeun and Ali Wong of "Beef" also had historic wins at the 75th Primetime Emmy Awards, in a Martin Luther King Jr. Day ceremony that was finally held four months late after a turbulent year of strikes in Hollywood.

"Succession," the HBO saga of the dysfunctional generations of a maladjusted media empire, won the top prize for its fourth and final season. It also won best actress in a drama for Sarah Snook and best actor in a drama for Kieran Culkin.

"We all put our all into it, and the bar was set so high," Snook said.

"The Bear," the FX dramedy about a contentious family and a struggling restaurant at the center of the life of a talented chef, won best comedy series for its first season. It also made a meal of the comedy acting categories, with Jeremy Allen White winning best actor, Ayo Edebiri winning best supporting actress, and Ebon Moss-Bachrach taking best supporting actor. All three were first-time nominees.

"This is a show about family, and found family and real family," Edebiri said from the stage as she accepted the first trophy of the night at the Peacock Theater in Los Angeles.

Instead of the usual producer speeches, Matty Matheson, a real-life elite chef who plays a kitchen newbie and repairman on "The Bear," spoke for the show while surrounded by the cast near the end of the Fox telecast.

"I just love restaurants so much, the good and the bad, we're broken inside," Matheson said before getting a long kiss on the mouth from Moss-Bachrach.

Brunson won best actress in a comedy for the show she created, ABC's "Abbott Elementary," becoming the first Black woman to win the award in more than 40 years and the first from a network show to win it in more than a decade.



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You can learn to forgive yourself for what you perceive to be your past mistakes. It may be that you had made the wrong choice in the past -- in that the decision made a significant impact on your life.

Taurus: You can currently forgive someone who is no longer in your life. Whether they are no longer on this plane of existence or just somewhere else in the world, this person likely is no longer around you.

Gemini: Old hurts can presently be soothed. You're likely spending time around people that you may have not fully trusted before, as they could have been standoffish or cold the last time that you were around them.

Cancer: Your public persona might be getting an update. You may have been holding back from updating others, in person or online, but you're ready to come out of the shadows and show people who you are!

Leo: The high road has your name on it, Leo. Someone may be attempting to irritate you into acting outside of your character, but you're unlikely to take the bait.

Virgo: The weight of emotions shouldn't be discounted at this time. Even if you aren't immediately connected to any sorrow or stress currently in your midst, the echoes of their pain can still affect you.

Libra: Past injuries, physical or emotional, don't have to damage your current life. Being involved in a similar situation to one that hurt you isn't fun, but it does present you with an opportunity to alter what you've done.

Scorpio: You might be forgiving someone that you don't really want to forgive. Even when you know it would be healthier to forget this person and move on, the hurt that they caused you might still be lingering.

Sagittarius: Laughter can be the best medicine. In particular, if you've been struggling with a past event that's possibly connected to an embarrassment that you carry with you, it could be causing insecurity for you in other areas.

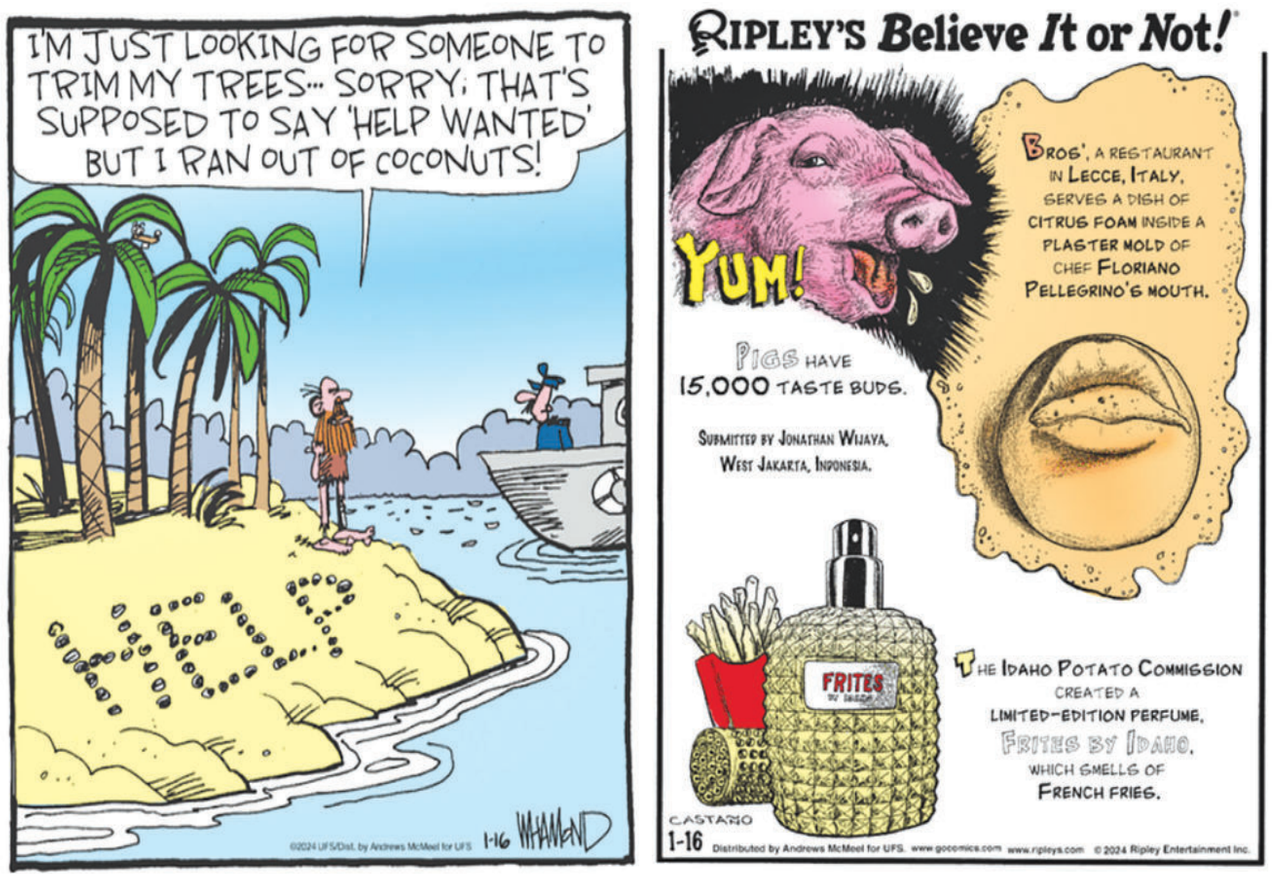
Capricorn: Opportunities to heal are presently all around you. You could be dealing with a fresh hurt, one that you may not want to admit to others, and so you are self-soothing through isolation.

Aquarius: Caring about anything is a choice. At the moment, it might seem easier to pretend that you don't care, when in reality, you're hurt over the things that others say and do.

Pisces: Others may mean well, but the road paved with good intentions isn't a good path right now. Peers are potentially warning you to avoid pursuing unfamiliar endeavors or chasing risky dreams that you're trying to achieve.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



One century a day: the trend continues at PM Men's Cup

Nepal Police, Bagmati, Sudur Pashchim win on Day 4.

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 16

With Nepal Police's Rashid Khan scoring a century on the opening day of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament on January 13, APF's Sundeep Jora reached the 100-run mark on Sunday. Captain of the Tribhuwan Army Club, Binod Bhandari, scored the third century of this tournament on Monday.

The trend of at least one century on a match day continued on Day 4 on Tuesday as Koshi Province's left-handed batsman Sujan Thapaliya gave continuity to it in the match against Nepal Police Club at the TU International Cricket Ground.

Thapaliya entered the pitch in the fourth over after the fall of two wickets when the team was at only seven runs. He faced Nepal Police bowlers for the next 42 overs before getting caught by Sunil Dhamala in the bowling of Karan KC. Thapaliya returned to the pavilion after scoring 106 off 126 balls with six fours and eight sixes.

Karan KC took a total of three wickets, Lalit Rajbanshi and Sunil Dhamala took two each, and Rashid Khan, Sagar Dhakal and Kushal Bhurtel claimed one each.

It was thanks to Thapaliya's efforts that Koshi was able to paste a target of 167 to Nepal Police. Captain Ankit Subedi and Aviyash Timsina were the only others to score in two digits for Koshi as the team was bowled out in the 49th over.

Meanwhile, every batsman who entered the pitch for Nepal Police in the chase scored in two digits. Bhurtel and Dhamala were expected to give Police a good start; however, Bhurtel, who was playing the first match of this edition, was caught behind the stumps in 2.4 overs after scoring 12 off 10 balls. Bhurtel was not inducted into the squad against Bagmati on the opening day of the tournament.

Dhamala joined Bhurtel in 7.1 overs after scoring 16 off 18. Arjun Saud and Dilip Nath then took the team forward. Nath was caught in the 17th over leaving the team at 96 for 3.

Nepal Police captain Dipendra Singh Airee came above the set lineup after Nath's wicket and took the team to the win with Saud. Remaining not out at 62 and 38, Saud and Airee scored 169 in 23.1 overs and won the match with 161 balls remaining.

In another match of the day at Mulpani International Cricket Ground, Bagmati, who was playing its third match, was able to grab its first win in the tournament against Madhes. Bagmati lost to two departmental teams – Nepal Police and APF – on Day 1 and 2 respectively.

Madhes, who won its first match against Koshi, lost by 86 runs to Bagmati. Madhes won the toss and elected to bowl first and was able to restrict Bagmati to a chasable target of 191.

Rupesh Singh and Araniko Yadav took two wickets, and Rajesh Yadav, Ranjit Kumar, Harishankar Sah and Pawan Sarraf took one each for Madhes to bowl out Bagmati's batsmen in 49.2 overs.

Ashutosh Ghiraiya, who fell short of eight runs for a century on Day 1 and nine runs for a half-century on Day 2, could not reach a double-digit score against Madhes. Ishan Pandey and captain Rit Gautam could also only score 15 and 12 runs respectively. The middle order also failed for Bagmati.



PHOTO: CAN
Koshi Province's Sujan Thapaliya raises his bat after scoring a century against Nepal Police Club at TU International Cricket Ground on Tuesday.

It was Pratish GC's knock of 59 runs in 55 balls with four fours and four sixes that helped Bagmati reach at least 190. Nevertheless, Madhes failed to capitalise on the chase of a low target.

Pawan Sarraf was the highest scorer for Madhes with 45 followed by Mayan Yadav (31 runs) and Niraj Yadav (15). Five batsmen of Madhes were sent back to the pavilion on a duck. The team was bowled out at 104 runs at the end of the 29th over.

Surya Tamang took six wickets, with a hattrick in the 28th over, and Pratish and Ishan took two each for Bagmati.

On the other hand, Sudur Pashchim also won its match on Day 4. Karnali was defeated by Sudur Pashchim at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground by 134 runs.

APF Club, Sudur Pashchim and Nepal Police have won their first two matches in the league and are in the top three positions in the table respectively.

Sudur Pashchim gave a target of 278 to Karnali in the loss of five wickets. Openers Khadak Bohora and Tek Rawat made an opening partnership of 138 runs with a half-century for both. Kiran Thagunna also scored a half-century for the team.

The target was massive, yet Karnali was hopeful to win with the help of its batsmen. Nevertheless, it was not possible against Sudur Pashchim's bowlers.

Sher Malla took four wickets and Bikash Aagri took two wickets for Sudur Pashchim. Narayan Joshi, Bhoj Raj Bhatta and Naren Bhatta took one wicket each as Karnali was bowled out at 143 runs in the 38th over.

France protecting players from clubs' pressure in transfer market

AP
France, Jan. 16

France's union of professional soccer players is launching legal action to protect footballers from the mental pressure their clubs put on them when they are cold-shouldered until they sign a new contract or accept to leave.

With the winter transfer window up and running in Europe, the UNFP said on Tuesday it has commissioned a law firm to lodge a complaint with the Paris public prosecutor for extortion and harassment.

With its legal action — which does not target a specific side — the union wants to highlight the bullying that players have to endure when their clubs put them aside to force them into extending their deals, or agreeing on a transfer when they are no longer wanted.

"These practices which are widespread - 180 players since the start of the current season - are even claimed by the clubs, who no longer hesitate to use sophisticated means of communication to complete the ostracization of the players concerned," the union said in a statement.

The UNFP said such practices are contrary to the Football Charter and employment law, and may constitute a criminal offence.

"The use of moral coercion to induce a person to agree to sign or terminate a contract constitutes the offence of extortion," it said.

The union said it has identified in the press some 50 recent cases of "lofting," a widespread practice that involves keeping players on the sidelines in so-called loft training groups to increase pressure on them.

"In reality, the number of victims of these practices is much higher, as everyone knows," the UNFP said.

Earlier this season, French football's biggest star Kylian Mbappé was excluded from a pre-season tour of Asia and barred from training with Paris Saint-Germain's main first-team group amid a contract dispute with the club.

The striker later returned after "constructive and positive talks" between the two parties, the club said. Details of the supposed deal reached between Mbappé and PSG have not been revealed. According to reports in French media, the player agreed to forgo several financial bonuses if he moves, meaning he won't leave the club for free.

Before he joined Juventus on a free transfer in 2019, Adrien Rabiot was also kept on the sidelines for months by PSG as it became clear he wouldn't sign a new deal.

And last year another former PSG player, Hatem Ben Arfa, won a court appeal after the club was found guilty of moral harassment and ordered to pay a compensation fee of 100,000 euros ($108,840).

SNIPPETS

Sarina Wiegman to stay in England until 2027

London (AP): England coach Sarina Wiegman signed a contract extension on Tuesday that runs through to the Women's World Cup in 2027. Wiegman took charge of the Lionesses in September 2021, led them to the European Championship title in 2022 and then took the team to last year's World Cup final, where it lost 1-0 to Spain. On Monday, she won the FIFA award for the best women's coach in 2023. "I am so happy to have the chance to lead England through to 2027 after an incredible two and a half years," the Dutch coach said. Before the World Cup, Wiegman will lead England in the defence of its European Championship title. Qualification starts in April, with the tournament finals being played in Switzerland in 2025.

Nadal as tennis ambassador in Saudi Arabia

Riyadh (AFP): "Everywhere you look in Saudi Arabia, you can see growth and progress and I'm excited to be part of that," the 37-year-old Spaniard, winner of 22 Grand Slams, said in a federation press release. "I continue to play tennis as I love the game. But beyond playing I want to help the sport grow far and wide across the world and in Saudi there is real potential." The announcement comes after a busy 2023 for tennis in Saudi Arabia, which hosted its first ATP Tour event – the Next Gen ATP Finals in Jeddah – and closed out the year with exhibition matches pitting Novak Djokovic against Carlos Alcaraz and Aryna Sabalenka against Ons Jabeur. The five-year deal to bring the Next Gen ATP Finals to Jeddah "signals the country's intent to make tennis a major part of its international calendar and is the first of many likely professional tennis tournaments to be held in the country," the Saudi federation said.

Roma sacks Jose Mourinho

Rome (AFP): Mourinho departs Roma after an emotional two-and-a-half years in which he won the Europa Conference League in 2022, ending a 14-year trophy drought for the capital club. Roma said that Mourinho would leave alongside his staff "with immediate effect", adding that it was "in the best interests of the club" after a series of poor results left the team way off the pace in the Italian top flight. Italian media report that former Roma captain Daniele De Rossi, a World Cup winner with Italy in 2006, is the favourite to replace Mourinho as coach. Mourinho's contract was due to expire in June and although he had repeatedly stated that he wanted to stay on. Rumours of his departure grew more persistent after Sunday's dismal 3-1 defeat at AC Milan which left Roma ninth in Serie A, five points away from the Champions League positions.

Messi wins FIFA's best men's, Bonmatí takes women's prize

AP
London, Jan. 16

Lionel Messi landed another prestigious award in soccer — barely. The Argentina star needed a tiebreaker with Erling Haaland to win FIFA's best men's player prize on Monday.

He has national team captains to thank. The voting breakdown showed Messi and Haaland with 48 points each after voting by a global panel of national team coaches and captains, selected journalists, plus fans online. The tiebreaker was whoever had more first-place or "5-point" scores from the votes of national team captains. That category was 107 to 64 for the Inter Miami forward.

Neither player showed up at the awards ceremony at Hammersmith Apollo Theatre in West London. Kylian Mbappé, the third finalist, skipped it too.

Messi had moved from Paris Saint-Germain to Inter Miami and led the David Beckham-owned team to a little-known Leagues Cup title — all while single-handedly elevating soccer's relevance in the United States.

The 36-year-old Argentina star also topped Haaland and Mbappé for his eighth Ballon d'Or award last October.

World Cup champion Aitana Bonmatí showed up — and cleaned up. The 25-year-old Spain playmaker was named FIFA's best women's soccer player, building on her Ballon d'Or award last October, which followed a UEFA award in August.

And that was after she led Spain to World Cup glory and Barcelona to the Champions League title. She was named player of the tournament for both competitions.

Bonmatí won Monday over Spain teammate Jenni Hermoso and Colombia star Linda Caicedo. The women's eligibility period covered performances from Aug. 1, 2022, through the World Cup final last August.

Manchester City manager Pep Guardiola was named best men's coach, and England coach Sarina Wiegman took the women's prize. Guardiola led City to a treble of titles: Champions League, Premier League and FA Cup.

Messi secured the FIFA award for the eighth time in 15 years. He had won it last year, too, after leading Argentina to the 2022 World Cup title.

The men's award did not consider the World Cup, which ended 13 months ago. It recognized achievements from after the tournament through Aug. 20.

Messi's figures in France after the World Cup were good but unspectacular: nine goals and six assists in 22 games across all competitions.

The best goalkeeper awards went to Ederson of Brazil and Manchester City, and Mary Earps of England and Manchester United.



West Indies look to spring surprise on Australia

AFP
Adelaide, Jan. 16

For the Australians, the biggest challenge has been deciding on a replacement for veteran opener David Warner, who retired after their win over Pakistan at the Sydney Cricket Ground earlier this month.

They have settled on moving Steve Smith up the order and bringing back towering all-rounder Cameron Green to bat at number four, where he slots in for the Western Australia state side.

The rest of the team is unchanged from the one that beat Pakistan 3-0 in the just-completed series.

Smith said he had lobbied to replace Warner at the top of the order, adding that it allowed the selectors to pick Green at number four instead of asking him to open.

"They (selectors) were obviously very keen to get Cameron (Green) in the side as well and play our best six batters, and for me it didn't sit right to have him come in and bat up top," Smith told reporters earlier this week.

"I've played for a long time and I'm an experienced player, and I think it's something I should have done."

For the West Indies, however, it is a completely different picture, with seven uncapped players in their 15-man squad.

They will also be missing former captain Jason Holder and fellow all-rounder Kyle Mayers, who have both chosen to sit out the tour to concentrate on the T20 format.

The once mighty West Indies have not won a Test in Australia since 1997 and were soundly beaten when they toured last summer.

The only members of the squad with Test match experience are captain Kraigg Brathwaite, vice-captain Alzarri Joseph, Alick Athanaze, Tagenarine Chanderpaul, Joshua Da Silva, Gudakesh Motie, Kirk McKenzie and Kemar Roach.

Joseph said the West Indies had taken inspiration from how an unheralded Pakistan had pushed the Australians and even had chances to win two of the Tests.

"We're here to win two Test matches, we're not just here to play," Joseph said.

"We had a look at some of the things Pakistan did and we're going to try to implement some of them, but we all have different ways of doing things.

"For us, it's about being brave, being positive."

Joseph conceded the visitors were underdone in the Test arena, having played only six since their last visit to Australia just over 12 months ago.

Australia, by contrast, have played 17.

"I think last time our lengths were a bit short," Joseph said.

"We just need to be a bit fuller and stay patient. Basically, it's different to the Caribbean, with a bit more bounce.

"I've been coming from a lot of white-ball cricket so for me, it's getting back into red-ball lengths and holding that for a long period."

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:32 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions and mainly fair in the rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.0	4.5	0.0
Dipayal	23.8	5.3	0.0
Dhangadi	15.8	7.2	0.0
Birendranagar	23.0	5.2	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.8	11.2	0.0
Jumla	18.5	-5.2	0.0
Ghorahi	23.0	7.5	0.0
Pokhara	22.0	8.4	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.0	8.2	0.0
Simara	13.9	10.4	0.0
Kathmandu	19.5	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.0	9.2	0.0
Taplejung	18.2	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	18.7	7.6	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	0.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.6	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 17, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.62	Rs. 133.22
Euro	1	Rs. 144.42	Rs. 145.07
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.58	Rs. 168.34
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.10	Rs. 154.80
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.55	Rs. 87.95
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.29	Rs. 98.73
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.92	Rs.99.37
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.04	Rs. 9.08
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.52
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.36	Rs. 36.52
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.75	Rs. 3.77
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.11	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.27	Rs. 28.39
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.92	Rs. 9.97
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.74	Rs. 12.80
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.36	Rs. 19.45
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.95	Rs. 432.90
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.81	Rs. 353.40

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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